HT CHENNAI, NEW DELHI, MUMBAI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE*

Friday, April 10, 2026

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TCS beats Street, but ends FY26 with 1st revenue fall ▶P1

Govt to bar private lab tests of vaccines, biologics ▶P1

HT CHENNAI, NEW DELHI, MUMBAI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* VOL. 20 NO. 86

Friday, April 10, 2026

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Can AI find bugs we can't? Inside Anthropic's latest

BY SHOUVIK DAS

On Tuesday, Anthropic unveiled Project Glasswing, a group of top global tech firms. It will use AI to spot cybersecurity risks that human engineers find tough. Amid lack of cybersecurity skills and rising cyberattacks, this could be pivotal. *Mint* explains how.

AFP

1 What makes Project Glasswing relevant?

Co-founder and CEO Dario Amodei said Anthropic created the cybersecurity coalition on noting how capable its new 'frontier' AI model, Claude Mythos, is. The firm tested it to find thousands of critical software flaws, technically called 'zero-day vulnerabilities', within an unspecified period. This means a code glitch not found to date. Cyber attackers thrive on them and can bring down large enterprises and even states. Notable attacks include 'Stuxnet' of 2010 that targeted Iran nuclear research facilities, and 2017's WannaCry that exploited a zero-day exploit tool used by the US National Security Agency.

2 Is it a cybersecurity application for all?

No. Project Glasswing, at its core, is an AI model to find gaps in the most commonly used software, and write codes to make software patches for the same. Think of it as a layer of research to find new security flaws in softwares such as Apple's, Microsoft's and Google's iOS, Windows and Android operating systems. So far, this research has largely been done by human-led teams at firms such as Cisco, CrowdStrike, Fortinet, and Palo Alto. Cybersecurity apps use the research to update software patch repository and knowledge of risks, and enable services to build on Claude Mythos-like tools that find core vulnerabilities.

REUTERS

3 Which are the enterprises backing this initiative?

Initial corporate partners are 11 firms, including Amazon, Apple, Google, JPMorgan Chase, Microsoft and Nvidia. The firm will first offer $100 million in

QUICK EDIT

Software resilience

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) on Thursday reported a 1.6% net-profit fall in the January-March quarter from the preceding quarter to $1.5 billion on a revenue rise of 1.5% to $7.6 billion. India's largest software services company also reported three large deal wins worth $12 billion in contract value. Its resilience raises optimism over the future of India's tech firms in the face of an AI storm. Artificial intelligence is taking over coding, the industry's bread-and-butter for decades, which explains a prolonged slump in share prices. While they may have been blindsided by AI's emergence—and TCS's decision to invest in data centres was seen as the firm settling for a commoditized AI-related revenue stream—AI adoption has opened new opportunities. Integrating legacy systems with AI tools often calls for specialized assistance, especially in sectors where regulatory compliance affords no space for mishaps. Thus, although our tech firms have failed to ascend the global curve of software evolution, their prospects may not be as dismal as dismissive views of their capabilities would have us believe. So long as they're still expanding revenues and profits, they're still worthy businesses.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

The fact is, we don't truly know what the future holds for transits through the Strait of Hormuz, or for that matter, for the recovery of regional air traffic. What we do know is that growth will be slower—even if the new peace is durable.

usage revenue, after which Claude Mythos use will be on a paid basis. The project will later open to more firms. Anthropic is also engaging with the US government to show its capabilities.

4 Will the cybersecurity skill gap be fixed?

Cybersecurity needs extremely sophisticated knowledge of software, including legacy systems. But, world's most notorious cyber criminal groups, such as North Korea's Lazarus, and Russia's DarkSide and Fancy Bear, grab software flaws no one else can, and exploit them. Digitized operations mean such flaws can put industries at risk. Sophisticated AI tools are seen fuelling cyber attacks. Aditya Varma, public sector leader at Cisco, said Glasswing proves AI's high-value returns, not just code writing.

5 Does it hold any significance for India?

Prima facie not. It doesn't involve or target India and it's largely centred in the US. But, market experts see an eventual impact. Thursday, a Motilal Oswal note said Glasswing could change how enterprise software is set up, and eventually hurt India's already-battered IT services. It said Glasswing can fix a core issue Indian firms face—large stacks of code and IT assets "built over 15-30 years" that aren't monitored. "Many vulnerabilities remain undetected... and security work is often reactive after breach," it said.

KRISTALINA GEORGIEVA
MANAGING DIRECTOR, INTERNATIONAL MONETARY FUND

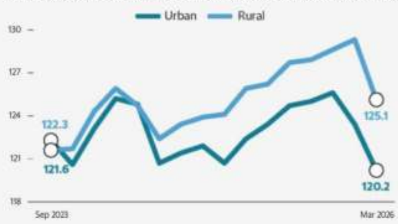
INSIDE

mint | DATA BITES

CONSUMER OPTIMISM TAKES A HIT ACROSS INDIA IN MARCH

The central bank's future expectations index (FEI) for consumer confidence declined in March: rural FEI fell for the first time since July 2024, while urban FEI dropped to its lowest since July 2023.

Future expectations index in RBI's bimonthly Consumer Confidence Survey



The index is based on households' perceptions for one year later on five parameters: economy, employment, price levels, household incomes and overall spending. An index value above 100 indicates net positive sentiment, while a value below 100 indicates net negative sentiment.

Data: Rupanjal Chauhan; Graphic: Prateek Kumar

Source: Reserve Bank of India

COLUMNS

ANDY MUKHERJEE
CAN THIS CEASEFIRE RELIEVE RETAIL INVESTORS OF GLOOM? MAYBE NOT >P13

Arun Maira
ARE OUR DIPLOMATIC AND ECONOMIC STRATEGIES WORKING? >P12

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PLAIN FACTS

DATA RECAP THE WEEK IN CHARTS

CURATED BY NANDITA VENKATESAN

From the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) holding the policy rate steady at 5.25% amid the war in West Asia, to the government raising fertilizer subsidy for the upcoming kharif season, net demat account additions slowing down in FY26, and India's ports logging strong growth in cargo traffic—here's a round-up of this week's news in numbers.

WAIT AND WATCH

GDP growth projections (in %) given by the RBI in...

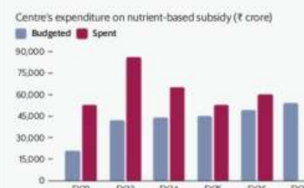
*Based on 2012 series. The February policy gave projections only for Q1 and Q2.

Source: Reserve Bank of India

THE MONETARY policy committee of RBI kept the repo rate unchanged at 5.25%, reflecting the wait-and-watch approach adopted by peers such as the Federal Reserve, Bank of England, and European Central Bank amid the West Asia war. The RBI pegged FY27 GDP growth at 6.9% under the new GDP series, down from FY26 growth estimate of 7.6%. The central bank flagged risks from Strait of Hormuz disruptions and high energy prices. It trimmed growth estimates for the first two quarters of FY27 compared with its February outlook—Q1 to 6.8% from 6.9% and Q2 to 6.7% from 7.0%. In February, the RBI had released data for only the first two quarters of FY27 pending the updates in the GDP series.

FERTILIZER SHIELD

Centre's expenditure on nutrient-based subsidy (₹ crore)



Revised estimates used for 2025-26 spent value.

Source: Budget documents

THE UNION cabinet has approved ₹41,534 crore in nutrient-based subsidies (NBS) for phosphatic and potassic fertilizers for the 2026 (FY27) kharif season, ₹4,317 crore higher than the subsidy announced for kharif 2025 (FY26). The increase follows higher prices of key fertilizer inputs amid the West Asia conflict.

India is the largest importer of Diammonium Phosphate (DAP) and a major buyer of other fertilizers.

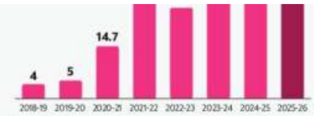
The higher outlay risks pushing up India's fertilizer subsidy bill. For FY27, the government has budgeted ₹54,000 crore for NBS of the total fertilizer subsidy allocation of ₹1.7 trillion. Past trends show the actual spending has often exceeded the budgeted amount.

TEPID SHOW

Net additions of demat accounts (in million)

NUMBERS TALK

- **41:** The number of consecutive days Iran's nation-wide internet blackout has lasted as of Thursday, amounting to 960 hours, according to NetBlocks. It is the longest countrywide shutdown on record.



Source: CMIE

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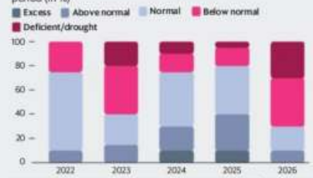
AFTER TWO years of strong expansion, new demat account additions slowed in FY26, signalling a shift in retail investor behaviour amid volatile markets and weaker returns, *Mint* reported. Net additions fell to 32.1 million from a record 41.1 million in FY25, a 22% year-on-year drop, according to data from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE).

The slowdown coincided with weak market performance, with benchmark indices posting their poorest showing in six years amid US tariffs and the West Asia war. Demat accounts stood at 224.5 million as of FY26. Additions had surged 142% on-year in FY22, eased in FY23 and picked up again in FY24 and FY25.

- **$730 million:** The amount raised by Agratas Energy Storage Solutions, Tata Group's battery arm, from banks in 2025. It has pledged all its movable assets to secure part of the borrowing.
- **$1 billion:** Value of the contract Wipro has won from the Olam Group, its first mega deal in nearly six years. As part of the deal, Wipro will acquire Mindsprint, Olam's IT arm, for $375 million.
- **Up to 15%:** The rise in blue-collar worker hiring costs over the past month, as a scarcity of LPG has forced some workers to move back to their towns and villages, *Mint* reported.
- **200:** The number of roles Meta plans to eliminate at its Silicon Valley office, as chief Mark Zuckerberg boosts the firm's AI push and streamlines its workforce. The cuts will take effect in late May.

MONSOON RISKS

Probability of monsoon rainfall during the June-September period (in %)



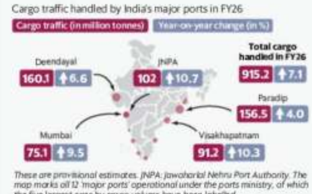
Source: Skymet

mint

INDIA IS likely to see below-normal monsoon in 2026 due to the emergence of El Niño conditions, private weather forecaster Skymet said on Tuesday, pegging the cumulative rainfall at 94% (±5%) of the Long Period Average (LPA) for the June-September season. El Niño is a climatic pattern often linked to a higher risk of low rainfall and drought in South Asia. Skymet sees a 30% probability of drought and a 40% chance of below-normal rainfall this year—the highest since 2023, when an El Niño event occurred. The India Meteorological Department will issue its forecast later this month. A weak monsoon could weigh on farm output, rural demand and food prices, posing risks to inflation and growth.

MARITIME GROWTH

Cargo traffic handled by India's major ports in FY26



These are provisional estimates. JNPA: Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority. The map marks all 12 'major ports' operational under the ports ministry, of which the five largest ones by cargo volume have been labelled.

Source: Ports, shipping and waterways ministry

mint

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

MAJOR INDIAN ports handled 915 million tonnes (mt) cargo in FY26, up 7.1% year-on-year and surpassing the annual target of 904 mt, according to government data.

The ports, shipping and waterways ministry said the growth was driven by improved operational efficiency, modernization of port infrastructure and increased handling of key commodities.

Gujarat's Deendayal Port handled the most cargo at 160 mt, up 6.6% on year, followed by Odisha's Paradip Port (156.5 mt, up 4.0%), and Jawaharlal Nehru Port in Navi Mumbai (102 mt, up 10.7%). Goa's Mormugao Port handled the least cargo at 21 mt, but posted the fastest growth at 15.9%.

MINT BEST OF THE WEEK

IPO REALITY CHECK

What once felt like easy money is now far from certain, retail investors are pulling back as listing gains fade and volatility rises. From blockbuster debuts to muted or negative returns, the initial public offering market is shifting towards caution, with firms delaying listings and investors becoming more selective.

HEALTHIER IPL ADS

Indian Premier League (IPL) advertising is shifting from indulgence to wellness, with pharmaceutical and health brands entering a space long dominated by fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) and electronics, reflecting changing consumer preferences. Scan the QR code to know more.

ADANI FIGHTS SEC CASE

Gautam Adani and his nephew have moved a US court to dismiss the Securities and Exchange Commission's securities fraud case, arguing lack of jurisdiction and denying any wrongdoing. Their lawyers say the alleged actions were outside US oversight. Scan the QR code for more.

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Real money gaming firms eye new playing fields ▶P10

Tata Steel postpones UK breakeven by a year ▶P6

SENSEX **76,631.63 ↓ 931.27** NIFTY **23,775.1 ↓ 222.25** DOLLAR **₹92.51 ↓ ₹0.03** EURO **₹108.18 ↓ ₹0.05** OIL **$96.24 ↑ $1.37** POUND **₹124.21 ↑ ₹0.07**

TCS beats Street, but ends FY26 with first revenue fall

Weak India business drags revenue; company expects better show this fiscal

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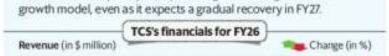
Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) closed fiscal year 2026 (FY26) with a modest recovery in quarterly

SALES SLIP

Macro uncertainty, early AI impact weigh on the IT giant's traditional growth model, even as it expects a gradual recovery in FY27.



coming year.

The management's upbeat commentary comes as the company has struggled to grow more than 5% in the past three years, slower than peers Infosys Ltd and HCL Technologies Ltd. At 19.28% on the BSE, its shares have also fallen the high-

Govt to bar private lab tests of vaccines, biological products

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India plans to restrict the testing of vaccines and specialized biological products exclusively to government-controlled laboratories to maintain quality standards, according to two government

DON'T MISS

PTI

RBI tightens norms to speed up inbound remittances

The RBI on Thursday tightened rules on how banks process inward cross-border payments to reduce delays in crediting funds to beneficiaries and align India's payments framework with the G20 roadmap for faster, more transparent global transfers. >P5

growth, but not enough to offset a broader slowdown that pushed it into its first full-year revenue decline in dollar terms since listing.

The results underscore a shifting demand environment, where macro uncertainty and the early impact of artificial intelligence (AI) are beginning to weigh on the information technology (IT) services giant's traditional growth model, even as the company expects a gradual recovery in FY27.

On Thursday, TCS reported a 0.5% decline in full-year revenue in dollar terms to $30.08 billion, alongside a 3.5% rise in net profit. In the fourth quarter, revenue grew 1.5% sequentially to $7.62 billion, indicating a mild pickup in momentum toward the end of the year.

Much of the annual decline was driven by weakness in its India business, whose revenue fell 32% during the period.

In rupee terms, revenue trends differed due to currency movements. Fourth quarter revenues registered a 5.4% sequential rise to ₹70,698 crore and full-year revenue rose 4.6% to ₹2,67,021 crore.

The company's management struck an optimistic note on the outlook for FY27, amid heightened macro volatility, particularly due to the West Asia conflict.

K. Krithivasan, chief executive of TCS, said during the post-earnings analyst call on Thursday that despite global uncertainty, the company continues to see strong client engagement and long-term deal commitments, positioning it for improved performance in the

TECH BYTES

REVENUE rose in rupee terms due to a weaker currency

HEADCOUNT fell by 23,460, after the co's biggest layoff in FY26

SHARES of TCS have lost 19% of their value this year

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

est among peers since January.

To be sure, the fall in full-year revenue was anticipated by experts, with TCS's final number beating a *Bloomberg* estimate of 46 analysts of $28.55 billion.

"Results are in line with expectations; a revenue decline was baked in last year itself," said Sushovon Nayak, lead IT analyst at Anand Rathi Institutional Equities.

"TCS must double down on winning more deals in its BFSI, consumer, and energy and utilities, and these would probably drive growth in the year. Additionally, bagging more legacy modernisation deals and AI-related client business focus may drive growth going forward," Nayak added.

Banks, consumer companies, and utilities companies make up more than half of the company's full-year revenue.

On AI, the company said that while customers want to accelerate

TURN TO PAGE 6

officials and documents reviewed by *Mint*. The new approach will affect private laboratory operators and the pharmaceutical manufacturers that rely on them for faster testing turnaround times.

Currently, private labs are allowed to test specified drugs including vaccines and biologicals. However, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) is now planning a major policy shift, and took up the matter for discussion at a drugs consultative committee meeting last month.

"The CDSCO believes that the specialized nature of vaccines warrants a more restrictive testing environment. Another objective is also to bring uniformity across all testing platforms," one government official said, requesting anonymity. "The new policy in the works would mandate that manufacturers of biological

The move follows criticism for lax oversight. AP

products route their batch testing through authorized government institutions like the National Institute of Biologicals based in Noida, effectively de-authorizing private labs for this specific category of medicines."

Currently, the Drugs and Cosmetic Rules, 1945, has provisions for the approval of standalone private laboratories to test the identity, purity, quality and strength of drugs and raw materials on behalf of licensed manufacturers.

There are seven Central Drug Testing Laboratories and 36 state drug testing laboratories across India. In the private

TURN TO PAGE 9

Aluminium makers feel the squeeze as caustic soda spikes

At a time when Indian aluminium prices are expected to remain higher for longer due to the West Asia war, key industrial chemical caustic soda is further fuelling manufacturing costs, with effects set to ripple across the broader economy. >P2

UpGrad's CFO, other senior executives quit

UpGrad is seeing senior-level exits as it integrates Unacademy after acquiring the K-12 edtech startup, ahead of a potential IPO next year. Group CFO Venkatesh Tarakkad, and upGrad Enterprise CEO Srikanth Iyengar, among others, are on their way out. >P3

Sebi asks brokers to tighten agent oversight

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has been asking brokers to step up checks on authorized persons (APs) and reinforce compliance every few months, according to three people familiar with the matter. >P4

March inflation hit one-year high: Poll

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India's retail inflation likely rose to 3.4% in March, but only marginally up from 3.2% in February, according to a median forecast of 16 economists in a *Mint* poll. The rise will push inflation to a 12-month high in March, up from a 10-month high in February. The data, however, is not strictly comparable due to the base year revision (from 2012 to 2024) from January 2026.

The March figure will be below the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) 4% medium-term target, even as war-led inflationary pressures are building up. Inflation will likely be driven by a fading base effect and rising prices in non-food segments, while the status quo on fuel prices and some moderation in gold and silver prices could offset some of the rise.

March figure may be driven by a fading base effect. ISTOCKPHOTO

This will be the third consumer price index (CPI) print under the new series with the 2024 base year. Economists in the poll expect March CPI to be within a wide range of 3.1% to 4%, with some flagging upside

TURN TO PAGE 6

Kitchen relief for migrants planned

Harsh Kumar & Dhirendra Kumar
NEW DELHI

Amid early signs of migrant workers returning to their hometowns, the Centre is planning targeted steps, including subsidized community kitchens and assured cooking gas supply, to retain them in India's key manufacturing hubs, two people in the know said.

The proposal, discussed at a finance ministry-led meeting on Wednesday, seeks to stabilize labour supply amid rising cost of living and fuel supply constraints due to the Iran war, and to prevent disruption to the vulnerable medium and small industries, they said.

The meeting, conducted in a hybrid-mode, was attended by senior officials from the ministries of finance and MSME (micro small and medium enterprises) as well as industry representatives. It took up a range of issues, including credit guarantees for MSMEs and mechanisms to prevent the retreat of migrant labourers, and ensure uninterrupted sup-

Proposal is to stabilize labour supply as living costs rise. MINT

TURN TO PAGE 9

EVs begin to move the needle for Auto Inc

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Aggressive electric vehicle (EV) plays by Mahindra & Mahindra (M&M) and Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd played a big role in EVs making up a fifth of the over 540,000 additional vehicles sold in fiscal year 2026 (FY26), data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (Fada) showed. That number was 8% in the previous fiscal year.

The two companies together accounted for 61% of India's electric car market in FY26, helping them power past second-placed Hyundai Motor in India's passenger vehicle (PV) pecking order (Maruti Suzuki is No. 1).

According to data from Fada, overall car retail sales grew 13% to 4.7 million units in FY26, while EV sales increased 84% to 199,923 units in the same period, contributing 4% to the overall market.

Mahindra & Mahindra and Tata Motors together accounted for 61% of India's electric car market in FY26. ISTOCKPHOTO

EVs have also contributed handsomely to the top carmakers' incremental growth last fiscal.

Fada data showed that M&M's overall sales jumped 22% year-on-year (y-o-y) in FY26 to 631,638 units, within which EVs have grown at an outsized 407% y-o-y to 42,721 units, and contributed 30% to the company's incremental sales growth.

Meanwhile, Tata Motors PV's retail sales rose 14% y-o-y to 613,513 units in FY26, even as its EVs showed a growth rate of 36% y-o-y to 78,811 units. Significantly, EVs contributed about 26% to the company's incremental growth.

Strip out EVs, and growth rates drop to 17% and 12% for M&M and Tata Motors PV, respectively.

Hyundai Motor, which ended the fiscal year below No. 2 (at No. 4) for the first time in 17 years, grew at just 3% to 578,337 units in FY26, even as its EV sales grew at a healthy 137.6% to 5,885 units. However, Hyundai's EVs contributed a lower 14% to its incremental sales, compared to the other two companies.

To be sure, EVs are not the sole driver of growth—M&M's strong SUV portfolio, for instance, continues to underpin its performance. But electrification is increasingly amplifying gains for early movers.

"Over the past six years, we have built the widest portfolio of electric vehicles across every major body style and price point,

TURN TO PAGE 6

Govt to streamline initiatives aimed at promoting biogas. HT

India among fastest-growing in FY27 despite war risks: WB

Geopolitical instability could keep oil prices higher, weighing on growth outlook: World Bank

Subhash Narayan

such as Thailand and South Korea.

Indian delegation to visit US in April for trade talks, says Gor

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The US on Thursday said it looked forward to hosting the Indian delegation

LNG supply woes spur India's compressed biogas push

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The Centre is looking to boost the production and adoption of compressed biogas amid a global liquefied natural gas (LNG) supply squeeze.

The government will scale up the ongoing biogas programme and streamline all initiatives aimed at promoting biogas, which is a sustainable alternative to natural gas, and if scaled up, can help reduce import dependence for LNG, said Neeraj Mittal, secretary at the ministry of petroleum and natural gas, at a conference titled *Energy Security: Driving India's Next Wave of Gas Demand* organized by the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB) and Indraprastha Gas Ltd (IGL) in New Delhi.

"The prime minister has directed us to really upscale the compressed biogas programme. It is a programme that has been parented by five departments so far for various subsidies, various parts of their supply chain. So, we are working very fervently to come up with a single programme."

Noting that ethanol procurement, production, and blending in the country have been streamlined, the secretary said the government will develop a similar road map for compressed biogas, which can then be blended with natural gas in the city gas distribution network.

The petroleum ministry launched the SATAT (Sustainable Alternative Towards Affordable Transportation) scheme in 2018, with the aim of establishing an ecosystem for the production of compressed biogas from various waste and biomass sources and promoting its use alongside natural gas.

Another programme, the National Biogas Programme, was rolled out in 2021 by the renewable energy ministry with a plan to set up biogas plants for clean cooking fuel, lighting, meeting thermal and small power needs.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

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NEW DELHI

India is expected to remain among the world's fastest-growing major economies in 2026-27 despite headwinds from the West Asia war, supported by strong macroeconomic fundamentals, said Aurelien Kruse, lead economist for India at the World Bank (WB) on Thursday.

The country has built robust buffers, including adequate foreign exchange reserves, a predominantly domestically held public debt profile, a well-capitalized banking system, low inflation and a relatively low dependence on net energy imports as a share of gross domestic product (GDP), the senior World Bank economist said.

Aurelien Kruse, lead economist for India at the World Bank, noted that India's exposure to global energy volatility remains relatively contained. AP

However, risks remain tilted to the downside. An extended period of geopolitical instability could keep global oil prices elevated for longer, potentially weighing on India's growth outlook. "While India's strong macroeconomic buffers offer some protection against downside risks, the conflict underscores the importance of energy diversification, prudent fiscal management and trade diversification," Kruse said while briefing the media on the bank's latest India Development Update released on Thursday.

The World Bank's South Asia chief economist, Franziska Ohnsorge, said that even with a moderation in growth, India's economic momentum remains strong.

"Even with our projection of lower 6.6% growth for 2026-27, the country would remain among the fastest-growing economies globally. This reflects strong buffers and policies that continue to support growth while maintaining fiscal consolidation," she said.

6.6% The WB projection for India GDP growth in 2026-27

In its latest South Asia Economic Update released on Wednesday, the World Bank projected India's economy to grow at 6.6% in 2026-27, slower than the estimated 7.6% expansion in 2025-26. The moderation reflects the impact of global uncertainties, particularly the US-Israel and Iran war.

The multilateral lender's projection is slightly lower than the 6.9% growth forecast by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) in its latest monetary policy statement, and the government's estimate of 6.8-7.2% made in January, before the escalation of tensions in West Asia.

Kruse noted that India's exposure to global energy volatility remains relatively contained. Net energy imports account for about 2.8% of GDP, significantly lower than several other energy-importing economies.

India is exposed to volatility in energy markets, but its exposure is still lower compared to peers. With plans to diversify energy import sources, the country is better placed to manage such shocks," he added.

The India Development Update is a companion piece to the World Bank Group's South Asia Economic Update, which examines economic developments and prospects in the South Asia region.

The latest South Asia Economic Update, Working with Industrial Policy, projects growth in South Asia to slow to 6.3% in 2026-from 7% in 2025, due to disruptions in global energy markets. Despite the slowdown, South Asia continues to grow faster than other emerging markets and developing economies. Growth is expected to recover to 6.9% in 2027. "South Asia's mixed success on industrial policy in part reflects the region's limited implementation capacity, fiscal space, and market size in some countries," said Ohnsorge.

6.9% Growth forecast by the Reserve Bank of India

"While broad-based reforms remain the priority, well-calibrated industrial policies could address specific market failures, including through measures such as industrial parks, skill development programmes, market access assistance and improving export quality standards."

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

here later this month to discuss the bilateral trade deal agreed to in February.

US Ambassador to India Sergei Gor made the announcement of the Indian delegation's upcoming visit to Washington after a meeting with America's Trade Representative Jamieson Greer here.

Gor, who is currently on a visit to the US, also met Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and several other US officials.

"Highly Productive meeting with @USTradeRep Ambassador Greer to discuss advancing @POTUS trade priorities in South and Central Asia," Gor said in a post on X.

"The United States and India have previously agreed to a trade deal, and we look forward to welcoming an Indian delegation to Washington later this month," he said.

The meeting comes a day after Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri launched the India-US Trade Facilitation Portal here as the two countries eye the $500 billion bilateral trade target.

India and the US announced a framework for an interim trade agreement in February, after months of negotiations between the two delegations.

This is a framework that promotes reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade, enhances market access and strengthens supply chain resilience immediately through expanded preferential access, rigourous rules of origin and addressing non-tariff barriers across various sectors.

India and the US announced an interim trade pact in February.

In a post on X after his meeting with the Treasury Secretary Bessent, Gor described him as a "true leader who's done an incredible job in handling complex economic issues."

Gor said he met Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau "to discuss his recent trip to the region and the future of commercial diplomacy in South and Central Asia, especially in AI, emerging technology, infrastructure building, and critical minerals.

"He (Landau) looks forward to returning to India, Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan. Dep Sec Landau has been a rockstar since day one," Gor said.

India caps refinery margins after windfall tax to offset fuel losses

PTI
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NEW DELHI

After imposing a windfall tax on fuel exports, India has moved to cap refinery margins in a bid to offset losses on domestic fuel sales, sources said.

The war in West Asia has had two prolonged impacts—spike in international oil prices that has led to record losses on petrol and diesel sales as retail rates have not changed in tandem. Secondly, it has given bumper margins to refineries, who irrespective of retail price freeze, price their products at imported cost.

The government last month imposed a Special Additional Excise Duty (SAED) on exports of diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF), as part of efforts to curb windfall gains by refiners and boost domestic fuel availability amid tight global markets.

Alongside, refining margins have been capped at $15 per barrel, with any earnings above that threshold treated as a discount on fuel sold to state-run marketing companies, effectively transferring excess gains to offset retail losses, people aware of the matter said.

Refining margins have been capped at $15 per barrel.

The oil marketing companies (OMCs) on March 26 fixed rates for petroleum products that are at a discount of up to ₹60 per litre to their imported cost. OMCs have decided to fix a discount on the refinery transfer price (RTP)—the internal price at which refineries sell fuel to marketing arms—to effectively pay refineries less than the import-parity cost of the fuels like petrol and diesel.

For the second half of March, a discount of ₹22,342 per kilolitre (₹22.34 per litre) was fixed on diesel to bring down the RTP of ₹85,349 per kl to ₹63,007 per kl.

For the first fortnight of April, the discount on diesel has been fixed at ₹60,239 per kl to lower RTP from ₹146,243 per kl to ₹86,004 per kl. On ATF, the RTP has been slashed to ₹76,923 per kl from ₹127,486 per kl after considering a discount of ₹50,564 per kl.

The RTP for kerosene after a discount of ₹46,311 per kl has been fixed at ₹77,534 per kl from ₹123,845 per kl, they said.

Traditionally, petrol and diesel in India have been priced on an import parity basis, meaning the fuels are valued as if they were imported, even though it is primarily crude oil that is brought into the country and refined locally. Refinery transfers of these products to oil marketing companies were based on import parity price until June 2006, after which the government adopted trade parity pricing—a benchmark that assigns 80% weight to import parity price and 20% to export parity price.

Caustic soda bites aluminium makers

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NEW DELHI

At a time when Indian aluminium prices are expected to remain higher for longer due to the West Asia war—impacting industries from automobiles and beverage cans to construction and even space tech components—a key industrial chemical is fuelling manufacturing costs, with effects set to ripple across the broader economy.

Rising energy costs due to the war disruptions have pushed up caustic soda prices by as much as 20% in India. Used widely across industries—from refining alumina and making paper, textiles, soaps and detergents to treating water, the chemical is now raising the cost of manufacturing aluminium for smelters run by Hindalco Industries and Vedanta Aluminium, as it is crucial in extracting alumina from bauxite ore, the primary raw material. With a capacity of 4.1 million tonnes per annum, India is world's second-largest aluminium producer after China.

The country is self-reliant in caustic soda. In FY25, India produced about 5,020 kilotonnes, while the domestic demand was about 4,625 kilotonnes. Around 11% of the output was exported, with 15% of the cargoes going to West Asia.

Higher aluminium prices are impacting industries from automobiles and beverage cans to construction. BLOOMBERG

Vedanta, which accounts for nearly half of India's aluminium output, declined to comment. Queries sent to Hindalco, which produces 30-40% of the country's aluminium, on 8 April, remained unanswered till press time.

With a capacity of 4.1 million tonnes per annum, India is the world's No. 2 aluminium producer after China

Caustic soda price rise comes as a double whammy for the aluminium industry already dealing with a supply crunch triggered by the destruction of two major facilities in West Asia: Emirates Global Aluminium's Al Taweelah production site in Abu Dhabi's Khalifa Economic Zone and Aluminium Bahrain.

According to data from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy, global aluminium prices rose 10% to $3,370 per tonne in March 2026 from $3,065 in February.

Noting that damage to these two smelters could take 9-12 months to normalize, tightening aluminium supplies, global brokerage firm JP Morgan said in a 7 April note that it expects India's aluminium prices to "remain higher for longer, driving a sustained commodity upcycle". While exact quantities vary depending on the quality of bauxite ore about 170-200 kg of caustic soda is used to manufacture 1 tonne of aluminium, accounting for 4-5% of production costs, per industry estimates.

Crisil said domestic caustic soda prices were up 15–20%. "The ongoing conflict in West Asia has led to domestic caustic soda prices rising 15-20% year-on-year in March 2026. However, the increase is not due to supply-chain disruption, but an offshoot of higher energy costs. Notably, energy constitutes 30-40% of the cost of producing caustic soda...," said Sehul Bhatt, director at Crisil Intelligence.

Bhatt said Indian industries producing alumina—from which aluminium is derived—chemicals, paper, and textiles are likely to face "elevated input costs and margin pressure".

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

MINT SHORTS

India grants waivers for some ships to deliver Iran cargoes

New Delhi: To speed up the delivery of energy supplies from the Gulf, India recently granted waivers to allow two Iranian cargoes aboard an older tanker and another under international sanctions to enter its ports, two officials said. India is facing its worst gas crisis in decades, with the government rationing supplies to ensure supply to households. REUTERS

AFP

India to cut steel emissions by 25%, reduce coal reliance

New Delhi: India's steel mills aim to cut carbon emissions by about a quarter over the next decade and reduce reliance on coal, while the world's second-biggest producer of the alloy plans to more than double output, as per a document seen by *Reuters*. Under the proposed "National Steel Policy 2025", India aims to cut emissions from steel mills to 2 metric tonnes of carbon dioxide per tonne of finished steel by 2035-36, according to a draft Cabinet note dated 10 March 10, reviewed by *Reuters*. REUTERS

RBI proposes new safeguards to curb digital payment fraud

Mumbai: Complaints related to fraud have impeded the potential of digital payments in India, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said on Thursday. In a new discussion paper, the RBI proposed measures to curb fraudulent activity while granting customers greater control over their transactions. The discussion paper is open for public comments and feedback till 8 May, the RBI said. ANSHIKA KAYASTHA

MINT

Pharma-grade methanol faces supply squeeze

BLOOMBERG

New Delhi: India is struggling to bridge a logistical gap that leaves its pharma sector reliant on imports for a key chemical, even as domestic capacity sits idle. While state-run plants can increase pharma-grade methanol production, the distance between manufacturing hubs in the northeast and drug clusters in the west and south has created a distribution bottleneck. VIJAY C ROY & RITURAJ BARUAH

Online retail market crosses $65 bn in 2025, says report

New Delhi: India's online retail market capped 2025 with renewed vigour as e-retail gross merchandise value (GMV) scaled to nearly $65-66 billion, growing 19-21% in value terms, according to a report by Bain & Company compiled in collaboration with Flipkart. PTI

AFP

Power minister visits Bhutan, to focus on energy security

New Delhi: Union minister of power and housing and urban Affairs Manohar Lal arrived in Bhutan on Thursday on a four-day visit during which bilateral discussions will focus on energy security and sustainable development. His visit marks another important step in the deepening of India-Bhutan bilateral ties, a statement from the power ministry said. PTI

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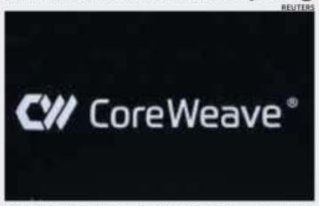
MINT SHORTS

Wow! Momo to add 200 outlets; eyes ₹1,200 cr revenue in FY27

Mumbai: Quick Service Restaurant (QSR) chain Wow! Momo Foods on Thursday said it is planning to add 150 to 200 stores in 2026-27, with a sharper focus on tier-II and -III markets, and targets a revenue of ₹1,200 crore. In FY26, Wow! Momo Foods opened 200 stores, the maximum annual store addition to date. With this expansion, the brand now operates over 850 outlets in more than 90 cities across the country. "200 stores and 40 new cities in a single financial year is a number we are proud of...," Sagar Daryani, co-founder and CEO, Wow! Momo Foods said. PTI

CoreWeave, Meta strike latest $21 billion deal for AI computing



REUTERS

CoreWeave Inc. has struck another, much larger $21 billion deal to supply computing power to Meta Platforms Inc. through 2032, deepening its business with the social media giant that's trying to catch up in the race to build more powerful AI models. CoreWeave will provide AI cloud capacity to Meta from multiple data centres powered in part by the Rubin systems of chips company Nvidia Corp., through December 2032, the company said in a statement Thursday. BLOOMBERG

Astranova Mobility raises ₹60 cr in a funding round led by IvyCap

New Delhi: Electric vehicle financing platform Astranova Mobility has raised ₹60 crore in a funding round led by IvyCap Ventures, the company said on Thursday. The round also saw existing investors —Asian Development Bank and Advantedge Founders. It also witnessed participation from Trucks Venture Capital, a Silicon Valley-based auto-tech fund, the company said in a statement. PTI

Agritech startup StarAgri to expand across north-east region

New Delhi: Agritech startup StarAgri on Thursday announced plans to expand its operations across North East India and tie up with local warehouse owners to standardize and upgrade facilities for the scientific storage of regional commodities. The company will also expand its workforce through its Guwahati branch office, hiring local youth for warehouse operations, it stated. PTI

upGrad's CFO, other senior executives quit

Exits come even as upGrad explores acquisitions, including parts of Byju's

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Ronnie Screwvala-promoted group's CFO is one of six senior executives exiting. MINT

Online education and skilling platform upGrad is seeing senior-level exits as it integrates Unacademy after acquiring the K-12 edtech startup, ahead of a potential public listing next year.

The Ronnie Screwvala-promoted group's chief financial officer (CFO), Venkatesh Tarakkad, and upGrad Enterprise chief executive officer (CEO), Srikanth Iyengar, among others, are on their way out, two people with knowledge of the matter said on the condition of anonymity.

Tarakkad's exit is significant because he oversaw finance, governance and compliance at the group level at a time when upGrad was sharpening its business ahead of a possible initial public offering (IPO), the first person said. He joined upGrad after serving as CFO at logistics provider Ecom Express and earlier as group CFO at TCNS Clothing Co. Ltd, where he led the company's IPO process and listing.

Iyengar led upGrad Enterprise, the company's business-focused skilling arm, and his exit comes amid a change of strategy at that unit, the second person said. Iyengar had been CEO of upGrad Enterprise since 2022, and previously held senior roles at QA Ltd, Conduent, Capgemini, IGATE and Infosys.

Besides Tarakkad and Iyengar, other senior executives who have exited the company include Sunita Mohanty, president and chief revenue officer, India, at upGrad Enterprise; Shantanu Gupta, AVP, finance, upGrad B2C; Naasha Cama, director, legal, upGrad B2C; and Reetesh Chandra, AVP, tech, upGrad B2C.

Mint reached out to upGrad and all six exiting officials mentioned in this story for comments and confirmation of the development. Tarakkad, Gupta, Cama, Chandra, and Iyengar confirmed their exits, while Mohanty, and the company had not responded to queries till press time.

The exits come at a sensitive time for upGrad as it streamlines operations and repositions parts of the business even as it works on the Unacademy integration. The exits also come as the company actively explores acquisitions, including select assets of Byju's.

SENSITIVE TIME

THE management churn is notable as upGrad is also preparing for a public listing

UPGRAD is looking at an initial public offering by 2027, targeting to raise $350-400 million

THE exits come at a time upGrad is also streamlining ops and repositioning parts of the business

The company is preparing for an IPO by 2027, targeting to raise $350-400 million, *Mint* reported in January.

Mint reported earlier that upGrad had signed a term sheet to acquire Unacademy in an all-stock deal expected to value its smaller rival at around ₹2,055 crore, or about $245 million, marking a more than 90% drop from Unacademy's 2021 peak valuation. The management churn is notable as upGrad works through integration planning, regulatory clearances and a broader internal restructuring while also preparing for a public listing.

upGrad Enterprise sells skilling and training programmes to companies, helping them address gaps in their workforce through courses tailored to business needs, according to a senior former upGrad employee who spoke on the condition of anonymity because he was not authorized to discuss internal matters.

In many cases, the unit works with clients to co-create courses for specific teams or functions rather than offering only standard modules, the former employee said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Bay Capital eyes ₹1,500 crore in new growth fund

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Bay Capital's India Digital Opportunities fund will back 10 to 15 companies. ISTOCKPHOTO

Bay Capital Partners plans to raise about ₹1,000-1,500 crore for a new fund targeting late-stage tech firms, joining investors chasing India's rapidly maturing digital economy.

The Mumbai-based firm's India Digital Opportunities Fund will back 10 to 15 companies in both private and public markets. To lead the vehicle, Bay Capital has brought in former Delhivery executive Sandeep Barasia and ICICI Ventures veteran Tej Kapoor as co-founders and managing partners.

"It's the first time we're doing a dedicated digital crossover fund. We're keeping the first fund fairly measured, so somewhere between ₹1,000-1,500 crore," said Barasia in an interview with *Mint*. "The idea is to find the right companies to back and deploy capital quickly."

The launch comes as India's venture and growth equity market, according to the India Venture Capital Report 2026, hit $16 billion last year, buoyed by a doubling of large deals. Investors are increasingly shifting toward crossover strategies that bridge the gap between Series C rounds and initial public offerings.

The fund aims to capitalize on an economy where 1 in 3 incremental rupees may be transacted digitally

The fund aims to capitalize on an economy where one out of every three incremental rupees is expected to be transacted digitally, according to Barasia. By targeting companies growing 60–70% annually, Bay Capital is betting on high-growth firms that require specialized guidance to navigate the tough task of taking a venture public.

The fund will target companies that are eyeing a listing within two to three years.

The India Venture Capital Report 2026 found that over the last year, fund-raising by venture capital (VC) and growth funds rose to around $5.4 billion, led by a surge in $100 million-plus vehicles. Investors are increasingly focused on firms demonstrating strong unit economics and clearer monetization pathways.

"We want to work with those founders at the growth stage, and there's still a lot of value that needs to be added. These aren't always companies that understand public markets; we're going to help them with that," Kapoor said.

Prior to his stint at ICICI Ventures, Kapoor served as country head of India at Fosun International, setting up their India investment strategy, and was the head of investments at South Africa-based Naspers.

Cycle Pure Agarbatti buys stake in Satvik

Vaeshnavi Kasthuri &
Sowmya Ramasubramanian
BENGALURU


Arjun Ranga, managing director, N. Ranga Rao and Sons Pvt. Ltd.

Cycle Pure Agarbatti is sharpening its push into digital channels and associated product categories as it looks to evolve beyond its traditional incense business. As part of this strategy, the company has acquired a majority stake in Satvik Spirituals Pvt. Ltd, a company that built its business of spiritual and lifestyle offerings through e-commerce.

"E-commerce is still relatively new for us and Satvik is a digital-first brand and understands consumer behaviour online," Arjun Ranga, managing director of N. Ranga Rao and Sons Pvt. Ltd, the parent company of the incense stick brand, said in an interview with *Mint*.

While the financial details were not disclosed, the move reflects Cycle Pure's intent to build online capabilities, diversify its portfolio beyond core puja consumables and leverage new-age consumer trends around convenience, design and authenticity.

The Mysuru-based company is looking to position itself as a broader spiritual lifestyle company, aiming to tap younger consumers and expand its presence in India's fragmented, fast-growing market for faith-based products and digital services such as online *aartis*, Ranga said.

This market is massive and still largely untapped. India's faith and religious products segment alone is already worth over $35 billion and remains ripe for digital disruption, according to a 2024 Redseer report.

The move reflects Cycle's intent to build online capabilities, diversify portfolio beyond core puja consumables

The company's move reflects the broader trend of a slew of direct-to-consumer (D2C) acquisitions by some larger FMCG companies in recent years to enter online commerce and tap into the young demographic. Reliance Consumer Products acquired ayurvedic beauty brand Pahadi Local and Marico picked up a stake in wellness brand Cosmix Wellness and snacking brand 4700BC.

Cycle Pure previously did not have a presence in the spiritual lifestyle products segment. While it has brands in agarbatti and puja consumables such as oil and wicks, categories such as *rudraksha* beads, jewellery and decorative accessories remained outside its portfolio.

"This is one segment where we were not present," Ranga said. "Satvik fills that gap beautifully with its range of authentic, lifestyle-oriented spiritual products."

Satvik works with over 500 artisans across northern India, sourcing products such as idols, puja accessories and gemstones.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Tesla developing smaller, cheaper EV

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Tesla has contacted suppliers in recent weeks to discuss details of the plan for an all new compact sport utility vehicle. REUTERS

Tesla is developing an all-new smaller, cheaper electric SUV, four people familiar with the matter told *Reuters*. The automaker has contacted suppliers in recent weeks to discuss details of the plan for the compact SUV—which would be a new vehicle and not a variant of Tesla's current Model 3 or Y, the people said. The conversations involved the manufacturing process and specifications for various components, they said.

or deny details of any specific vehicle but said, in general, the automaker now aims to build models that would be driverless but offer a human-driven option.

While aiming for full autonomy across its lineup, the person said, Tesla realizes many global markets won't see meaningful adoption—nor regulatory acceptance—of driverless vehicles for years. Preserving the option to build a particular model with or without driving controls could enable more sales and help ensure Tesla can keep its car factories running

Three of the people said the compact SUV would be produced in China, and one said Tesla also aims to expand production to the US and Europe. The car would be 4.28 metres in length, or about 14 feet, two of the people said. That's significantly shorter than Tesla's top-selling Model Y SUV, which is about 15.7 feet long.

The effort follows a decision by chief executive Elon Musk to scrap a highly anticipated low-cost EV project in 2024 and pivot the company to focus on robotaxis and humanoid robots. A key question is whether this latest effort to develop a smaller SUV signals a strategy shift back to mass-market human-driven EVs or whether the new model would align more with Tesla's vision for fully autonomous vehicles.

Such a model could potentially serve both purposes, according to one of the people familiar with the new-vehicle project and a Tesla employee with knowledge of its current product philosophy. The Tesla employee declined to confirm near capacity, the person said.

Tesla didn't respond to requests for comment about plans for a new vehicle.

The four people familiar with the project said it remained in an early development stage. *Reuters* couldn't determine whether Tesla has given the green light for the car's production.

Index	Close	Percent change	Previous close	Open	High	Low
BSE Sensex	76,631.65	-1.20	77,562.90	77,319.33	77,429.33	76,347.90
Nifty 50	23,775.10	-0.93	23,997.35	23,909.05	23,990.75	23,682.80
Nifty 500	22,037.50	-0.45	22,137.10	22,090.70	22,189.50	21,943.20
Nifty Next 50	66,268.65	0.19	66,145.30	66,079.25	66,605.50	65,592.10
Nifty 100	24,486.50	-0.73	24,666.70	24,587.55	24,682.50	24,390.05
BSE 150 MidCap	15,360.48	0.09	15,346.96	15,368.40	15,444.18	15,214.03
BSE 250 SmallCap	6,162.70	0.25	6,147.04	6,156.73	6,204.08	6,114.70

NMDC rally isn't just iron-ore led

Ananya Roy
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A price hike has lifted NMDC Ltd stock, but the bigger story may lie elsewhere.

Shares have surged about 8% this week after the miner raised iron-ore prices from 5 April. Prices of lumps and fines were hiked by ₹500/tonne and ₹450/tonne to ₹5,300 and ₹4,500, barely a month after increases of ₹100 and ₹50 were implemented on 6 March.

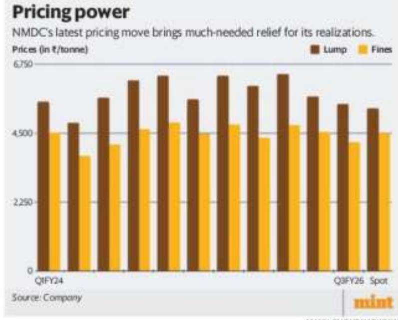
Markets cheered the move, interpreting it as a signal that pricing power may be returning to the ferrous cycle amid strong domestic steel demand and firm global prices.

Morgan Stanley also flagged restocking activity amid rising prices. Seaborne iron-ore prices have risen about 8% since end-February, partly aided by the West Asia war.

Brokers are divided over how profitability turned out for NMDC in Q4FY26, with Nuvama Institutional Equities estimating a 5% year-on-year decline in Ebitda per tonne, while Kotak Institutional Equities expects an 11% rise in the metric.

Pricing power

NMDC's latest pricing move brings much-needed relief for its realizations.



Source: Company

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Against this backdrop, the latest price hike is a relief, sending shares soaring. The stock has gained over 3% since end-February, outperforming the 5% drop in the benchmark Nifty 50 index, but barely extending the 35% rally seen in the past year. That indicates the bigger story lies elsewhere. NMDC has been hitting record production, and is diversifying into the country's priorities—critical and rare-earth minerals.

The company recently crossed 50 million tonnes (MT) in annual output for the first time, ending FY26 with 53 MT output, up 21% y-o-y. It is targeting 100 MT by FY30, backed by a ₹70,000 crore expansion roadmap.

India's steel consumption story continues to offer a long growth runway for NMDC, the country's largest iron-ore producer. With the government targeting 300 MT crude steel capacity by FY31, and realizations protected to an extent with safeguard duties, iron ore demand is expected at 430 MT, said ICICI Securities.

Optionality has also been emerging. Apart from diamond, gold, and coal-mining, NMDC is venturing into rare earth minerals with Gujarat Mineral Development Corp., aligning itself with India's push for self reliance in critical minerals.

While regulatory caps limit upside, rare-earth exposure strengthens the narrative quality that typically drives PSU stock re-ratings before earnings materialize.

STRATEGIC PRIORITIES

NMDC is hitting record production and is diversifying into critical and rare-earth minerals

STEEL demand offers a long growth runway for NMDC, India's biggest iron-ore producer

For NMDC, environmental clearance extends to 65 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) of capacity, putting expansion plans beyond FY27 at risk of regulatory delays. Another regulatory risk is Karnataka's proposed retrospective taxes on mineral-bearing land. Reports suggest the impact could be ₹14,000 crore for NMDC—large enough to alter the miner's earnings-growth plan. Net profit in FY25 and 9MFY26 stood at ₹6,540 crore and ₹5,400 crore.

Moreover, the durability of the recent pricing tailwinds remains uncertain. Guinea's Simandou Mine, often described as the world's largest mining venture, is expected to ramp up production to 120 MT of iron ore by 2030. Steel production in China, which faltered amid its property crisis, could pick up as the government pushes steel-sector reforms.

NMDC trades at 6.6x EV/Ebitda based on consensus *Bloomberg* estimates for FY27. Whether the current move evolves into a sustained rerating or remains a commodity-cycle bounce will depend on how execution pans out over the next few years.

Phoenix offers cheaper retail proxy. Real estate is the risk

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Shares of The Phoenix Mills Ltd have risen 7% in the past two sessions, buoyed by its Q4FY26 business update. While the quarter was robust for its retail consumption and hotel (hospitality) segments, residential pre-sales were a dampener, falling 43% year-on-year (y-o-y), mirroring broader trends across retail, hospitality and real estate.

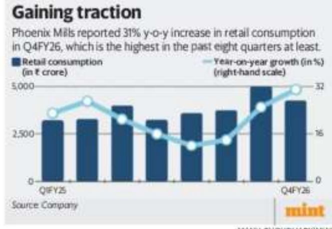
Phoenix's retail consumption growth of 31% y-o-y in Q4FY26 was the fastest in FY26, beating analysts' expectations. The performance is particularly notable as the company added no new malls during the year. Phoenix benefits directly when retail sales rise because its rental revenue model is closely linked to tenants' sales. In that sense, the stock doubles as a proxy play on retail consumption.

Nomura estimates Phoenix's retail rental revenue to grow 16% y-o-y in Q4FY26. For 9MFY26, retail consumption grew 17%, translating into a 9% rise in rental income.

Phoenix's multiple business lines often move in different directions, making consolidated Ebitda less useful as a yardstick, particularly because accounting for real estate construction differs from that for retail and hotels.

Gaining traction

Phoenix Mills reported 31% y-o-y increase in retail consumption in Q4FY26, which is the highest in the past eight quarters at least.



Source: Company

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Investors may instead want to focus on the segment that drives the bulk of the company's sum-of-the-parts valuation: retail leasing. According to Motilal Oswal Financial Services estimates, the retail leasing segment could post an Ebitda of about ₹2,900 crore in FY26, compared with roughly ₹400 crore from the hotel business.

With Phoenix's market capitalization at around ₹60,000 crore and net debt likely near ₹5,000 crore, the enterprise value works out to about ₹65,000 crore. After subtracting an estimated ₹13,000 crore in valuation for the construction and hotel businesses, the retail leasing arm is valued at about ₹52,000 crore, implying an EV/Ebitda multiple of 18x. That doesn't appear demanding when compared with listed retailers such as Trent Ltd and Avenue Supermarts Ltd, which trade at 40x and 55x Ebitda multiples.

For some investors, Phoenix could well be a case of retail proxy play at a cheaper valuation. While the risks from a slowdown in retail consumption apply to all retail firms, the other specific risks for Phoenix's investors could be aggressive deployment of rental leasing cashflows into real estate construction and hotels business that may not deliver comparable returns.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Ozone to raise up to ₹1,500 cr via IPO; appoints bankers

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MUMBAI


The firm procures products from China, Taiwan and the EU.

Nuvama-backed Ozone Overseas, which makes architectural hardware fittings, plans to raise ₹1,000-1,500 crore through an initial public offering (IPO), two people familiar with the matter said.

The company has appointed Motilal Oswal Alternates Investment Advisors, Axis Capital and Nuvama Wealth Management as bankers for the process.

If it goes as planned, the company will file its draft papers for a listing by the end of this financial year, the people cited above said on the condition of anonymity.

Volatile equity markets and slowing capital flows due to the West Asia war have forced several companies to defer or recalibrate their listing timelines this year.

The companies did not respond to *Mint's* requests for comments, sent on Wednesday, till the time of publishing.

India's home and furnishings market, valued at $34-36 billion in 2024, is witnessing a structural shift

India's home and furnishings market, valued at $34–36 billion in 2024, is witnessing a structural shift driven by rising disposable incomes, urbanization, and growing demand for branded, design-led offerings, according to a Redseer report. The market is expected to further grow at a CAGR of 11–13%, reaching $63-71 billion by 2030.

The report suggests that as consumer focus shifts toward lifestyle and aesthetics, integrated D2C players are primed to lead via multi-category expansion and omnichannel reach. In 2023, PAG-backed Nuvama bought a minority stake worth ₹250 crore in Ozone, helping the company expand its manufacturing capacity, reinforce brand presence, and explore potential synergistic acquisitions. The company was previously backed by private equity firm Everstone Capital.

Established in 1999 by Alok Agarwal, Delhi-based Ozone provides architectural hardware solutions including glass fittings, door-closing devices, door locks, electronic safes and fittings. The firm procures products from China, Taiwan and the EU and operates via a pan-India dealer network.

The group has a portfolio of about 4,500 products which are used in residential spaces, hospitals, government and private institutions, malls and airports.

Its revenues have grown at a CAGR of 24% for the last three years, Crisil said in a report last year. In FY25, Ozone reported a revenue of ₹560.24 crore, up from ₹522.73 crore a year ago. Its profit narrowed to ₹16.3 crore from ₹33.34 crore, as per Crisil's note.

The firm competes with Assa Abloy, Dormakaba, and Warburg Pincus-backed Ebco, according to online reports.

Sebi asks brokers to tighten agent oversight

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The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has been asking brokers to step up checks on authorized persons (APs) and reinforce compliance every few months, according to three people familiar with the matter.

"Sebi has been informally advising brokers to carry out annual checks and surveillance on authorized persons. They call every 2-3 months to reinforce this," said one of the three people cited above. "It does not want APs to engage in unau-


Sebi regulations restrict authorized persons from working across the board with all brokers.

past two years and they have been forced to bear immense

mentioned above said. NSE and Sebi did not respond to *Mint's*

Partners. Francis of Khaitan and Co. said that APs exploiting their relationship with clients often target people who are less financially literate. Such arrangements are not documented, and the investor continues to believe they are trading with the broker.

Investor risks have escalated with social media-driven trading. A 2025 survey by Sebi found that 62% of retail investors rely on finfluencers for investment decisions, with a significant proportion acting directly on such advice.

Many of these influencers operate in close proximity to authorised person (AP) net-

HAL's growth stalls on GE delivery delays

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In a market where defence stocks have largely remained in favour despite severe geopolitical strain, Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL) has been a bit of an outlier. The stock is down around 11% so far in 2026, while the Nifty India Defence Index is up about 4%.

HAL recently posted provisional FY26 revenue of ₹32,250 crore, only slightly higher than the ₹30,981 crore it reported in the previous fiscal year, because of delivery challenges in Light Combat

As per reports, GE Aerospace delivered the sixth F404-IN20 engine to HAL for the Tejas LCA Mk 1A on 2 April.

MINT

and eight Dornier aircraft worth ₹2,186 crore, the government-owned company said in the update. "The outstanding manufacturing orders for helicopters, aircraft, and engines provide long-term revenue visibility over the next 7-8 years," HAL said, adding that its repair and overhaul, spares and other segments also remained healthy and were expected to stay robust.

Yellapu of Anand Rathi Institutional Equities said the current dip could be a good accumulation opportunity for investors looking at a three to four year horizon as valuations appeared attractive. "A fresh thorized activities such as promising assured returns and collecting funds from retail investors with the intent of fraud."

India's vast network of over 100,000 authorized persons (APs)—agents who bring clients to brokers and facilitate trades—has been drawing increasing scrutiny as lapses in oversight and social media-driven investing expose retail investors to rising fraud.

While the AP framework, introduced in 2009, was intended to deepen market participation, it has created blind spots in supervision as brokers scale through agents. Industry executives say supervising the vast network has become increasingly challenging. Official data on their numbers is not publicly available.

"Such scams have always been around but have become more easily identifiable for Sebi. Victims have also started complaining more since the markets have been down in the losses," said Tomu Francis, partner at Khaitan and Co.

APs operate under brokers' control and cannot independently handle client funds or act outside regulatory limits. Sebi regulations restrict APs from working across the board with all brokers. An AP can be associated with only one trading member for a given segment and cannot be appointed by multiple brokers on the same exchange. They can affiliate with another trading member only for segments where their existing trading member is not registered.

India's network of over 100,000 authorized persons has been drawing increasing scrutiny

Stock exchanges have also stepped up engagement with brokers alongside Sebi. "NSE (National Stock Exchange) met all brokers a couple of weeks ago and told them again to ensure their APs do not engage in fraud," the second person queries sent on Wednesday.

Sebi's regulatory push comes amid formal investigations against brokers who failed to control their APs.

In November 2025, the regulator fined Angel One ₹300,000, citing unapproved trading terminals and inadequate internal audits after APs registered as employees under another AP were found trading among themselves. Motilal Oswal faced a similar ₹300,000 penalty in June 2025 for oversight lapses, including use of unqualified personnel and misuse of client credentials.

"APs sometimes go beyond their role as they want to earn more money. They start promising assured returns to clients they have a long standing relationship with," said Abhiraj Arora, partner at Saraf and works, either formally or informally, blurring the lines between advice, execution and fund handling.

Sebi has removed over 100,000 pieces of content for violations and uses artificial intelligence (AI) tools to track unregistered investment advice.

"Finfluencers who take trading courses also become APs or associate themselves with other APs and brokers to collect money from investors. As such instances rise, there have been more visible grievances in the last two years due to the market downturn," Francis said.

One high-profile case involved influencer Avadhut Sathe.

In December 2025, Sebi alleged that Sathe, through his trading academy, gave stock tips and engaged in unregistered investment advisory via online classes and webinars. The regulator disgorged over ₹500 crore for the violations.

Aircraft (LCA) Tejas MkIA and Hindustan Turbo Trainer-40 (HTT-40) due to supply-chain disruptions stemming from geopolitical and technical issues. This quickly shifted the focus to execution worries, with some analysts even trimming their estimates after delays in engine supplies from General Electric (GE). This issue, market experts said, is emerging as a key overhang on near-term growth visibility. The provisional FY26 revenue was about 7% below Nomura's estimate of ₹34,580 crore.

"The miss on our estimates was largely because no LCA MkIA aircraft were delivered in FY26 due to supply chain issues, falling short of our expectation of five deliveries," Nomura said on 2 April. Given the supply chain issues, the brokerage has cut its FY27 forecast for LCA deliveries from 14 aircraft to 10, while leaving its FY28 estimates unchanged. Nomura cut its earnings-per-share estimates for HAL by 7% for FY26, 5% for FY27, and 1% for FY28.

"Delay in supply of engines by GE has acted as a major bottleneck for HAL's timely delivery of LCA aircraft," the brokerage said. As of March, HAL had received just 5 engines from GE, against a commitment of 10, it said.

According to reports, GE Aerospace delivered the sixth F404-IN20 engine to HAL for the Tejas LCA Mk 1A on 2 April. HAL has reportedly levied liquidated damages on GE for the delay.

HAL has reportedly levied liquidated damages on GE for delays in supplying the engines

The engine makes up about 18-20% of the LCA aircraft's cost, leaving HAL heavily reliant on GE, the sole global supplier of these engines, said Santosh Yellapu, research analyst at Anand Rathi Institutional Equities. He said he sees the current engine supply delay as a temporary hiccup, but warned that any fresh tariff moves under the US President Donald Trump could disrupt GE's vendor ecosystem, creating more hurdles for HAL. "Margins aren't under meaningful pressure yet, but revenues have already taken a knock," he said.

Yellapu estimated HAL's sales could dip around 4% year-on-year in Q4, though the impact has been partly cushioned by higher volumes in other projects. HAL said in its provisional FY26 update that its order book was ₹2.54 trillion as of 31 March, up from ₹1.89 trillion at the start of the year (after adjusting for execution).

The jump was driven mainly by large orders from the defence ministry, including 97 LCA MkIA aircraft worth ₹62,370 crore, six ALH helicopters worth ₹2,704 crore,

wave of orders, like maybe for the Sukhoi Su-57, could act as a trigger for the stock's re-rating," he added.

Nomura said in its report that the risk-reward equation appears favourable as HAL's stock is trading at 18.5 times estimated FY28 earnings, compared to the five-year average one-year forward P/E of 26 times. "We're probably in the last leg of the downcycle. For investors with a two to three year view, a 40-50% upside looks quite likely," said Amit Anwani, vice-president, research, at PL Capital.

He also noted that based on HAL's one-year forward PE, it is trading at a discount to most peers, which offers comfort.

Sentiment remains firmly positive on HAL, with 20 brokerages maintaining a 'buy' rating, one suggesting investors hold, and only three recommending they sell, according to *Bloomberg* data.

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RBI tightens norms to speed up inbound remittances

Regulator seeks to align India's payments framework with the G20 road map for faster transfers

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The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Thursday tightened rules governing how banks process inward cross-border payments, seeking to reduce delays in crediting funds to beneficiaries and align India's payments framework with the G20 road map for faster and more transparent global transfers.

The central bank said delays often arise at the beneficiary bank stage, after the funds reach the bank but before they are credited to the customer's account, slowing the overall speed of cross-border payments.

"Review of the extant process for inward cross-border payments indicated the need for streamlining the processes at the beneficiary bank for ensuring timely intimation of payment information and credit to the beneficiary's account," RBI notified in the revised rules on Thursday.


The central bank said delays often occur at the beneficiary bank stage before funds are credited to customers. PTI

The new framework will come into effect after six months. Under revised rules, banks must inform customers immediately upon receiving a message that an inward cross-border payment is credited to them. Messages received after the close of operating hours must be communicated to customers at the start of the next business day.

The regulator also addressed delays caused by reconciliation practices. RBI said several banks rely on end-of-day statements of their nostro accounts to confirm receipts, which can postpone crediting funds to beneficiaries.

To expedite the process, banks have been directed to reconcile and confirm credits in their nostro accounts more frequently—either on a near real-time basis or at periodic intervals. "The reconciliation interval should normally not exceed one hour," RBI said.

This represents a relaxation from draft norms issued in October 2025, which had proposed capping the reconciliation window at thirty minutes.

A nostro account is a bank account held by a domestic bank in a foreign bank, denominated in that foreign country's currency. Such accounts are used to facilitate international trade and cross-border transactions, and allows banks to manage foreign currency liquidity and process payments without the need for foreign branches.

These guidelines will accelerate inward remittances by mandating hourly nostro reconciliation, same-day crediting during forex market hours, straight-through processing (STP) for individuals, and digital customer interfaces, said Utkarsh Bhatnagar, partner, Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas. "Implementation will require banks to upgrade real-time reconciliation systems, adopt automated STP infrastructure, and roll out digital platforms within six months, creating valuable opportunities to modernize operations and enhance customer experience."

QUICKER MONEY TRANSFERS

BANKS must inform users immediately once inward cross-border payment message is received

MESSAGES received after operating hours to be conveyed by banks at the start of next business day

BANKS to reconcile the nostro accounts more frequently to speed up payment confirmation

UNDER new rules, to be effective in six months, nostro account checks not to exceed one hour

RBI also urged banks to "endeavour" to credit inward payments received during foreign exchange market hours within the same business day, and those received after market hours on the next business day.

The central bank said banks may put in place straight-through processing for crediting inward payments to accounts of individual residents, based on their risk assessment and subject to compliance with Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999 guidelines.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Ex-DeepMind scientist bets on visual AI with new startup

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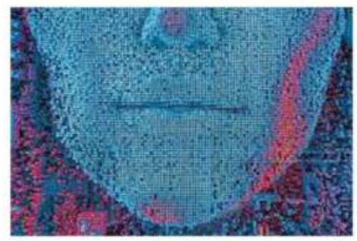
Former Google DeepMind researcher Andrew Dai believes that the artificial intelligence models at big labs have the intelligence of a three-year-old kid, at least when it comes to making sense of visual prompts. So he's co-founding a research startup to bring an adult into the proverbial room. The company, Elorian, is building AI that can better understand the imagery in the world around it. The breakthroughs could speed the deployment of AI in industries such as architecture, the automotive market and robotics, Dai said.


The company, Elorian, is building AI that can better understand the imagery in the world around it. ISTOCKPHOTO

Elorian is emerging from stealth mode on Thursday with $55 million in funding and a $300 million valuation. The Palo Alto, California-based startup, which has hired more than a dozen people, is working on building better-reasoning visual models.

Investors include Striker Venture Partners, Menlo Ventures and Altimeter Capital, with participation from Nvidia Corp. and noted AI researcher Jeff Dean.

AI firm Elorian, co-founded by researcher Andrew Dai, has raised $55 million at a $300 million valuation

The round was raised in two tranches, with the first capital coming in at a $120 million valuation and the second portion raised at a $300 million level, according to a spokesperson for Elorian. The Information previously reported on some details of the company's fundraising efforts.

Though the startup isn't yet generating revenue, it is having discussions with potential customers and plans to release its first publicly available reasoning model in approximately the next 12 months, Dai said. Elorian's other co-founders are Yinfei Yang, who worked on AI research efforts at both Google and Apple, and Seth Neel, a former Harvard professor who researched data and artificial intelligence.

Elorian's pitch: In order to help AI understand the world around it, the tech industry needs to build models designed specifically for that purpose. Despite the billions of dollars that companies such as Google and OpenAI have poured into building massive AI models, the tools still do a poor job of, say, visually analyzing satellite imagery or answering questions about what an image is missing but should have, Dai said.

While coding has brought reasoning capabilities to a different level, Dai said that models still can't handle major decisions on how to make lighter cars or more efficient rockets.

"These are not things you can just express with code and have a faster rocket. You actually need to design the physical thing—and that design lives in the physical world," he said.

OpenAI recently pulled the plug on Sora, its popular video generation app, which sparked some concern in the tech sector about the commercial viability of AI video. But Dai stressed the firm was less focused on creating media and more interested in reasoning capabilities.

"It's much easier to generate something that looks great, but it's a lot harder to reason about it, to understand it, to explain what it does to someone."

Elorian is developing its early AI products on top of open source models, which can be freely used and modified. The company is considering releasing smaller versions of its models to the open source community but will likely keep its flagship version proprietary, Dai added.

Dai is part of a wave of researchers who left labs in pursuit of more specialized work within the ever-changing world of artificial intelligence. For example, You.com founder Richard Socher has been raising capital at a $4 billion valuation for a more advanced AI system — technology that's still under wraps.

And Periodic Labs, which was co-founded by former researchers at Google and OpenAI, is currently fundraising at a $7 billion valuation. It launched with a valuation of more than $1 billion.

Panel to assess health insurers' concerns

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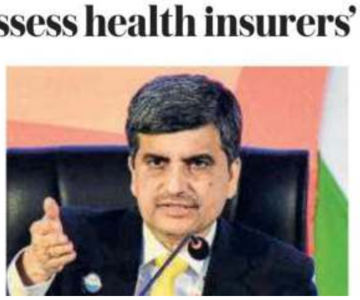
In an effort to improve policyholder experience and penetration of health insurance in the country, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) has constituted a sub-committee of the Insurance Advisory Committee. The insurance regulator notified the formation of the panel, its members,



speaker, author, and adjunct professor at Banasthali Vidyapeeth, Rajasthan, will also be members. Two insurance chiefs—Sanjeev Mantri, managing director and CEO of ICICI Lombard General Insurance and Krishnan Ramachandran, managing director and CEO of Niva Bupa Health Insurance, will be permanent invitees. The secretary of the Irdai Board Secretariat will convene panel meetings.

What issues will the

Sarovar Hotels opts for selective expansion despite high demand

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Sarovar Hotels Pvt. Ltd will go ahead with selective expansion spree in India's mid-market segment. While the chain crossed the ₹2,000 crore revenue mark in 2025, and is keen on further growth, its leadership wants to

international trips with high-end local locations.

The hotel chain is targeting ₹2,300 crore in 2026, and its next phase of growth will depend as much on viability and execution as on market opportunity. "Growth for the industry overall is going to be much bigger in the smaller cities," Ajay K. Bakaya, chairman of Sarovar Hotels and director,

SpiceJet ordered to pay about $8 million to engine lessor. MINT

UK court

role and scope, as well as the issues it will address on 2 April. *Mint* looks at the major hurdles that the committee could address:

What is the scope and objective of the panel?

The committee will evaluate private health insurance, from claims and pricing to fraud control, to recommend innovations that expand coverage and boost consumer trust. It will also explore aligning private insurers with public health schemes to improve efficiency and portability.

The panel has been constituted for a year. It will have to prepare and submit its first report with specific, actionable recommendations within four months.

The seven-member panel will be chaired by Irdai chief Ajay Seth and include regulators, experts and industry leaders. REUTERS

Why was there a need to set up a health insurance-specific committee?

EXPLAINER

Health insurers, especially standalone health insurance firms, are grappling with the operational impact of losing input tax credits. Friction with healthcare providers has exposed issues such as delayed payments for cashless claims, the need to streamline processes between hospital administrations and insurers, and surging medical inflation.

These challenges underscore the need for better coordination and uniform pricing for medical treatments.

Who are its members?

Irdai chairman Ajay Seth will head the seven-member committee, which will also include Deepak Sood, member (non-life) from the regulatory body. Indu Bhushan, former chief executive of the National Health Authority (NHA), and Monika Halan, a financial writer,

panel attempt to solve?

The sub-committee will investigate barriers to health insurance access and affordability, and evaluate whether current retail and group products meet consumer needs. It aims to streamline claims, transparency, and grievance redressal to strengthen policyholder protection and industry trust.

The key priorities include ensuring fair product pricing and establishing a master data repository that combines private and public data for better governance. The panel will also integrate industry recommendations on medical inflation, a unified code of conduct, and the expansion of the National Health Claims Exchange.

be choosy about locations to hedge against rising land costs and project delays.

The firm, majority-owned by Europe's Louvre Hotels Group, is prioritizing tier II and III cities, where infrastructure-led growth is outpacing the entry of branded players. "Growth for the industry is going to be much bigger in the smaller cities," Ajay K. Bakaya, chairman, Sarovar Hotels, and director, Louvre Hotels India, told *Mint*. However, high capital costs and shortage of hospitality talent are complicating the execution of new projects in the emerging hubs, he said.

The caution comes as the industry expects India's room supply to hit 350,400 by 2030 to keep pace with demand.

Ajay K. Bakaya is the chairman of Sarovar Hotels. MINT

Rivals like Lemon Tree Hotels are also racing for market share, yet Sarovar is focussing on mixed-use developments, combining hotels with branded residences to ensure long-term financial viability.

Despite domestic revenues currently tracking 5-6% below forecasts due to geopolitical tensions and soft sentiment, the group is committed to opening 20 hotels this year. By targeting spiritual circuits and industrial centres, Sarovar aims to capture a domestic travel surge that is increasingly substituting expensive

Louvre Hotels India, told *Mint*.

He said India's hotel sector is entering a phase in which demand is likely to continue running ahead of new room supply, held back by long project timelines, high capital costs, and approval bottlenecks. At the same time, he said branded operators need to be far more selective about where they expand, especially as land prices rise and staffing challenges intensify.

The Louvre Hotels Group is owned by China's Jin Jiang International. In India, Sarovar operates in 3-, 4- and 5-star categories under Sarovar Premiere, Hometel, Sarovar Portico, Golden Tulip brands.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

backs lessor in SpiceJet dues case

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A UK court has ordered India's SpiceJet to pay about $8 million to an aircraft engine lessor over unpaid rent and maintenance charges for three engines, in the latest setback for the cash-strapped airline. London's Commercial Court granted summary judgment on Wednesday in favour of Sunbird France 02 SAS over the unpaid rent and maintenance accruals, finding that SpiceJet had no viable defence.

The ruling comes as SpiceJet is under financial strain following the Boeing 737 MAX grounding and pandemic, and losing market share to rivals such as Akasa Air. The unpaid rent dates from January 2022, while maintenance accruals date back to November 2020. The lessor issued default notice in July 2022 and repossessed all three engines during late 2022-mid-2023.

The airline did not respond to an email seeking comment.

SpiceJet initially hired British solicitors but never filed a defence or response to Sunbird's application, judgment showed. Its auditors warned of uncertainty over its ability to continue as a going concern, citing mounting losses and a gap between liabilities and assets, show its latest results.

India's film industry weighs how long should movies stay in theatres

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How long are you willing to wait to see *Dhurandhar: The Revenge* or *Project Hail Mary*, released in March, on a favourite streaming platform? Eight weeks or four? That's the question that filmmakers and theatre owners are grappling with.

Film industry stakeholders are discussing whether a standard gap between theatrical release and streaming debut could work across languages.

Universal Pictures set a precedent by mandating an eight-week theatrical window globally before its films can be streamed. Many theatre owners in south India are demanding films follow a eight-week window for OTT premieres instead of four weeks.

Studio executives and cinema owners said the bigger issue is how box office performance aids the sale of ancillary rights. Many believe the window should depend on a film's scale and theatrical potential, since holding back a movie that fails to draw audiences makes little sense.

"From the exhibition side, a longer and more predictable theatrical window is something the entire ecosystem benefits from," said Ashish Misra, head of commercialization at Cinepolis India, which operates 449 screens in over 40 locations in the country. "When a studio like Universal extends its window globally, it reinforces what exhibitors have always maintained: theatrical revenue has room to grow when you give a film adequate time in cinemas."

Studios say the OTT release window for films like *Dhurandhar* should depend on a film's scale and box office potential.

However, the challenge with a purely movie-specific approach is that it creates uncertainty for the audience, Misra said. If a viewer does not know whether a film will be in theatres for four weeks or eight weeks, it may change their urgency to buy a ticket. "A baseline standard, even if individual films negotiate upward from there, gives audiences and exhibitors a degree of predictability that helps planning on both sides," he added.

STREAMING WINDOW

SEVERAL theatre owners are pushing for an eight-week OTT window instead of four weeks

OTT platforms are increasingly linking acquisitions of movies to box office performance

Experts said the conversations need to involve producers, distributors, exhibitors and streaming platforms. Each has a different revenue model and a different relationship with time. What makes this complex is that it is not just a commercial decision—it shapes audience behaviour.

"India is a very diverse market with multiple language industries, so a single standard window may be difficult. We may see broader alignment in principle, but not necessarily a one-size-fits-all model," said Abishek S. Vyas, founder and CEO of AVS, an arts and entertainment company based in Dubai and Mumbai operating across film production, art licensing, audio media and content-driven intellectual property.

Executives said streaming platforms themselves benefit from a theatrical release, a point reinforced by the current trend where platforms refuse to pay high upfront fees and instead link movie acquisitions to their box office performance. A senior executive at a streaming platform said there is a move towards a more dynamic, data-led model rather than fixed timelines.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Tata Steel sees breakeven in UK delayed by another year

Rising costs by West Asia war may offset gains from recovering steel prices, policy support

Dipali Banka & Abhishek Law
MUMBAI/NEW DELHI

Tata Steel expects its UK business to take another 12 months to break even, as rising costs driven by the West Asia war may offset gains from recovering steel prices and policy support aimed at reviving its loss-making operations in the UK, chief executive T.V. Narendran told *Mint*. This is the second time India's second-largest steelmaker revised its Ebitda (Earnings Before Interest, Taxes, Depreciation, and Amortization) breakeven guidance. It had originally targeted September 2025 and later deferred it to March 2026.

"We had previously said that if steel prices go up by about 100 pounds, it will break even... It is already up by about 100 pounds now... But costs have also gone up. So I don't want to say the price point at which we will break even. But we will break even this fiscal year," Narendran said on the sidelines of an All India Management Association conference in New Delhi on Thursday.

The comments underscore Tata Steel's delicate balancing act in the UK, where it has struggled with structurally higher costs, including energy and logistics, even as market conditions begin to improve.

Tata Steel's confidence is buoyed by import restrictions that the UK government has announced to support domestic steel production. The company had long flagged the need for regulatory backing to make its UK business viable and shield it from cheap imports, particularly as it transitioned towards greener steelmaking technologies.

In March, the UK government said starting 1 July 2026, it will slash steel import quotas by 60% relative to current safeguard levels. Any steel entering the country beyond these new limits will be hit with a 50% tariff. "This measure will apply to imported steel products that can be made in the UK," Peter Kyle, secretary of state for the department of business and trade, said in a statement on 19 March.

Tata Steel chief executive T.V. Narendran highlighted that while Indian steel consumption continues to grow at a robust 8-10%. PTI

While Tata Steel's Netherlands operations have remained profitable, the UK unit has been a persistent drag on overall European performance. The planned shift towards electric arc furnaces and greener production methods is expected to gradually improve cost efficiency.

Tata Steel UK contributes almost 10% to the steelmaker's total revenue from operations. It has been importing steel substrate (slabs and hot-rolled coils) to feed its UK downstream operations following the closure of Port Talbot blast furnaces in 2024 as part of the shift toward greener steelmaking. For the first nine months of the fiscal year, the business reported an Ebitda loss of £170 million.

COLD METAL

WEST Asia war increases costs, offsetting benefits from higher steel prices.

TATA Steel UK stays loss-making, while Dutch operations continue generating profits steadily

TRANSITION to greener steelmaking expected to improve efficiency, reduce costs gradually

INDIAN operations deliver strong growth, contrasting with declining UK performance

For Narendran, who took over as chief executive in 2017, the business increasingly reflects a tale of two geographies, with India delivering record performance and the UK continuing to drag consolidated earnings. In FY26, India operations posted a best-ever crude steel output of 23.48 million tonnes and deliveries of 22.53 million tonnes, with domestic volumes crossing 20 million tonnes for the first time. In contrast, the UK business remained subdued, with deliveries declining to 2.21 million tonnes amid weak market conditions and the ongoing transition.

Narendran highlighted that while Indian steel consumption continues to grow at a robust 8-10%, the company's profit margins are being squeezed by the surging costs of shipping, insurance, and raw materials. With steel prices trending upward since late last year, Tata Steel believes the worst may be behind it, setting the stage for a breakeven in the UK business by FY27.

However, the lack of clarity on the exact breakeven price point reflects the ongoing volatility in input costs, suggesting that Tata Steel's turnaround in the UK will depend as much on cost control as on sustained price recovery.

In March, the board approved an equity infusion of up to $2 billion (around ₹18,500 crore) into T Steel Holdings Pte. Ltd, its Singapore-based holding arm for international operations. The funds will be deployed in tranches to support overseas subsidiaries through capital expenditure, restructuring costs, and debt repayment.

Tata Steel entered Europe through its $12 billion acquisition of Corus Steel in 2007, which included the Port Talbot plant and operations in the Netherlands. In 2024, the company received a £500 million grant from the UK government as part of a £1.25 billion for a 3 MTPA green steel project at Port Talbot.

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European alcohol firms seek tariff relief

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NEW DELHI

A European industry lobby group, whose members include Pernod Ricard, Anheuser-Busch InBev, Heineken and Carlsberg, has asked India for an exemption from a 10% import duty on glass bottles and aluminum cans, amid shortage fears triggered by the Iran war, a letter, seen by *Reuters*, shows.

The Federation of European Businesses in India wrote to the government on 2 April highlighting that companies' can and bottle supplies were hit as local manufacturers couldn't operate at optimal capacity.

This highlights pressures in India's $65 billion alcohol market facing higher costs for glass bottles, cartons and labels due to the Middle East crisis. In India, it is tough for companies to pass this on to customers as price changes need government approvals in about two-thirds of India's 28 states.

The drinks industry in the country is already facing an up to 15% cost increase due to higher prices of raw materials.

The Federation's letter requested "a temporary customs duty waiver on packaging imports for aluminium cans and glass bottles," adding that exploring alternative sourcing options from other countries could add 30% to costs.

India's commerce and finance ministries did not respond to queries. The Federation of European Businesses in India declined to comment. Pernod Ricard, AB InBev, Heineken and Carlsberg did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

MOVES

A weekly list of C-Suiters who have moved up the corporate ladder either within or outside their companies.

Aditya Kohli	Appointed as **chief human resources officer - India** at **Tenneco**
Amar Sinha	Appointed as **managing director** at **Allied Blenders & Distillers**
Ameya Velankar	Appointed as **group senior vice president marketing** at **Ixigo**
Amit Malik	Appointed as **vice president people and culture India and South Asia** at **Accor**
Arjun Kalra	Appointed as **head of marketing - India and South Asia** at **Uber**
Arun Srivastava	Appointed as **chief executive officer** at **Numeros Motors**
Arvind R P	Appointed as **chief executive officer** at **Lenexis Foodworks**
Atish Bhattacharya	Appointed as **head of human resources** at **RAK Ceramics**
Gaurav Mittal	Appointed as **head of mergers and acquisitions** at **Allen Career Institute**
Manish Maheshwari	Appointed as **head of growth and revenue, India** at **Stripe**
Neha Saxena Shenoy	Appointed as **chief human resources officer** at **Emaar India**
Pallavi Poddar	Appointed as **chief human resources officer** at **Knauf India**
Pankaj Rathi	Appointed as **chief financial officer** at **Religare Housing Development Finance**
Prabhjot Minhas	Appointed as **senior director and head of marketing, India** at **Oracle**
Rajesh Jain	Appointed as **chief people officer** at **Vishvaraj Environment**
Samir Agrawal	Appointed as **president** at **Strata Geosystems**
Saugata Mukherjee	Appointed as **head of content** at **YRF Entertainment**

EVs move the needle for Auto Inc

FROM PAGE 1

from hatchbacks to high SUVs, enabling the democratization of EVs," Vivek Srivatsa, chief commercial officer, Tata Passenger Electric Mobility Ltd, said.

"EVs contribute 14-15% to our passenger vehicle portfolio, significantly ahead of the industry average of ~4%, with customers driving more, travelling farther, and increasingly choosing EVs as their primary car, reflecting growing trust in the technology," he added.

M&M, Hyundai India and Maruti Suzuki did not respond to queries seeking comment on their EV sales and plans.

Subhabrata Sengupta, a partner at Avalon Consulting, noted that EV sales act as incremental sales boosters for some manufacturers, but the decision on whether to go big on the technology is a strategic choice.

"It is a growing segment. Whether you play there or not is always a strategic choice. Toyota grew around 20% without an EV," Sengupta said.

So far, Maruti and Hyundai have not yet gone big on the

Global EV sales declined year-on-year in Jan and Feb. MINT

segment. Maruti, which sold 1.86 million cars in FY26 at a growth rate of 11.4%, started selling EVs in India only in February, with just over 1,400 units registered. As of now, it sells just one EV, the eVitara.

Hyundai on the other hand, sells two EVs in India—Creta EV and Ioniq—even as it discontinued the Kona EV last June for want of demand.

Comparatively, M&M and Tata Motors have close to half a dozen EVs each. Last fiscal, Tata Motors PV launched the Harrier EV and the face-lift of Punch EV. And M&M launched two electric models—XEV 9S and 3XO EV.

However, both Maruti and Hyundai have big plans. Maruti Suzuki will inaugurate a 250,000-unit production line in FY27 at its Hansalpur facility in Gujarat, which is expected to be dedicated to EVs. The company expects 15% of its sales to come from EVs by FY31 as it expands its EV portfolio.

"There were some initial delays but now the ramp-up is progressing steadily," Rahul Bharti, senior executive officer-corporate affairs at Maruti Suzuki, told *Mint* earlier on scaling up EV production.

Hyundai, meanwhile, has lined up five models for launch by 2030 in a bid to capture greater market share.

The trend also stands out against a slowing global backdrop. EV sales in key markets such as the US and China have seen volatility amid shifting policy support, making India one of the more resilient growth markets for the technology.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

India inflation likely rose to 3.4% in March 2026: *Mint* poll

FROM PAGE 1

risks as the war has driven crude oil prices sharply higher.

"Headline CPI is expected to rise in March, led by an increase in non-food segments, even as food inflation is expected to remain steady," said Aditi Nayar, chief economist at Icra Ltd.

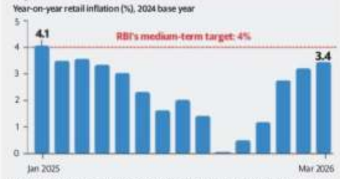
Some economists flagged a fading base effect as another key driver. Dhiraj Nim, economist at ANZ Bank, said a fading base effect, particularly in the food basket, would likely push headline inflation higher. "Overall, headline CPI remains benign, but it is accelerating," he added.

A few economists also highlighted the inflationary impact of the rise in prices of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), aviation turbine fuel (ATF), and kerosene—all of which came under pressure after the West Asia war began on 28 February. Effective 7 March, domestic LPG cylinder prices rose by ₹60, while commercial cylinder costs increased by more than ₹100.

Price pressure

A few economists highlighted the inflationary impact of the rise in prices of LPG, ATF and kerosene—all due to the West Asia war.

Year-on-year retail inflation (%), 2024 base year



March CPI is based on the median of forecasts by 16 economists in a Mint poll

Source: Statistics ministry, Mint poll

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

"Higher energy prices in March will be reflected in the CPI only to the extent that they passed through to domestic gas prices, which were hiked modestly," ANZ's Nim said.

The Centre and oil marketing firms have so far shielded consumers from high crude prices, though pump prices could rise if oil stays high. Crude prices have eased since a two-week US-Iran ceasefire came into effect on 8 April, but they remain well above pre-war levels.

Most economists in the poll said risks to the inflation outlook are tilted to the upside, though much will depend on how long the conflict lasts.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Umang Agarwal	Appointed as **managing director, India** at **TR Capital**
Venkatesh Kidambi	Appointed as **managing director India** at **OneMagnify**

Source: Accord India, executive search worldwide

India's generic copies dent Eli Lilly's sales

Bloomberg
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The flood of cheap copies of Novo Nordisk A/S' blockbuster drug semaglutide in India is already reshaping the country's fast-growing obesity market, cutting into Eli Lilly & Co.'s early lead and offering a first real test of how Novo may fare as its patents expire worldwide.

Lilly to see a global generic rush as patents expire. REUTERS

Within days of dozens of generics hitting the Indian market, semaglutide's share in the country's GLP-1 segment jumped to 33% in March from 25% a month earlier, according to researcher Pharmarack. That gain came at the expense of tirzepatide—the active ingredient in Lilly's Mounjaro—whose share fell to 64% from 71%, Pharmarack said.

The data, which counts sales of non-branded versions between 21-31 March, marks the first meaningful snapshot of demand after India opened the door to non-patented semaglutide. While Canada was the first country to lose semaglutide patent protection in January, regulators there haven't approved any generics so far.

It also offers an early sign of the rush to generics Lilly will face globally as semaglutide approaches patent cliffs elsewhere. The price war and demand surge are closely watched as patents for the treatment expire in major emerging markets this year, with India a key test case for how quickly generics can erode a branded drug's dominance.

Mounjaro sales in March dropped to ₹114 crore ($12.3 million) in March from ₹135 crore a month earlier, Pharmarack data show. Lilly will lose exclusivity next decade.

This is a "gold rush phase" as generics come on board, said Sheetal Sapale, vice president of commercial at Pharmarack. Though Mounjaro still dominates the market in India, it's taken a "major hit" following the launch of semaglutide copies, she said.

Representatives for Novo Nordisk and Eli Lilly didn't immediately respond to requests for comment.

Torrent Pharmaceuticals Ltd. has emerged as the biggest local player in semaglutide after Novo, trumping rivals including Sun Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd. and Dr Reddy's Laboratories Ltd. Torrent has an 8% market share, while Novo still holds 70%, according to Pharmarack.

Indian drugmakers moved quickly after semaglutide's patent expired on 20 March, rolling out versions that cost as little as ₹1,290.

TCS beats Street, but ends FY26 with first revenue fall

FROM PAGE 1

adoption, clients lack AI-readiness.

"We're working with our customers to address this gap by upgrading their infrastructure to be scalable and secure, modernizing their core applications and setting up modern data foundations," said Aarthi Subramanian, chief operating officer of TCS, during the company's analyst call. "A significant part of the technology spend is being invested in these areas."

A second expert said TCS's revenue decline indicates that AI is testing the IT services industry's core model.

"Clients are no longer buying effort, they are demanding outcomes," said Phil Fersht, chief executive of HFS Research.

"AI is compressing delivery timelines, reducing headcount intensity, and forcing providers to deliver more value for less revenue in the short term," Fersht added. "That creates a very real tension: strong bookings on one side, but muted revenue realization on the other."

TCS reported $2.3 billion in annualized AI revenue for the January-March 2026 period.

Meanwhile, the company's net profit for the full year jumped 3.5% to $5.94 billion. This came despite $157 million in severance-related payments to employees who were let go and also a one-time impact from labour codes, which will raise gratuity payments to employees.

Its profitability rose 70 basis points to 25% which the management primarily attributed to the layoffs. A hundred basis points equal 1%.

TCS reported $2.3 billion in annualised AI revenue for the January-March 2026 period. BLOOMBERG

Samir Seksaria, chief financial officer of TCS, said the company successfully mitigated headwinds by improving business mix, productivity and realization by 100 basis points.

"Rebalancing of the pyramid helped by 80 basis points. And support from currency also benefited margins by another 190 basis points," he said during the company's post-earnings analyst call.

This is in line with previous years, when the company has traditionally maintained the highest profitability amongst its peers.

Another silver lining was the company's increase in large clients fetching upwards of $100 million annually, which rose by two last fiscal to 66.

In December, the company won a mega deal valued at more than $1 billion in revenue over 10 years from Telefónica UK, the British arm of Spanish telecom giant Telefónica. The company renewed its billion dollar IT transformation deal with UK-based retailer, Marks & Spencer, and also bagged a mega deal with a US-based healthcare and pharma company.

A silver lining was TCS's increase in large clients fetching upwards of $100 mn annually, which rose by two

The increase in margins came with a decrease in headcount. TCS ended last fiscal with 584,519 employees, down by 23,460 from the year ago. Much of this can be attributed to its largest layoff drive last year. In July, the company said it would give marching orders to 12,200 middle and senior-level employees who could not be reskilled.

According to a *Mint* report dated 6 April, at least 300, or 16% of its senior executives left the company since it announced layoffs. The company incurred $157 million in severance-related costs last fiscal year. The management also announced a company-wide wage hike for all eligible employees with top performers getting 'double-digit' hikes.

India's first class action hits snag as lead petitioner exits

Lead shareholder Ankit Jain has sought to exit the class action suit against Jindal Poly Films

Krishna Yadav & Yash Tiwari
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

India's first class action suit has hit an unexpected hurdle: Ankit Jain, the lead minority shareholder in the ₹2,500-crore siphoning case against Jindal Poly Films, is looking to walk away. Having sold his shares in the company, Jain, who previously represented a 4.99% minority stake alongside other petitioners, has now moved to exit the landmark legal battle.

Jain's legal team informed the Delhi principal bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) on Thursday that he had divested his entire shareholding and no longer had the legal standing to appear as a petitioner leading the class action. Jain was among the original petitioners, along with Rina Jain and Ruchi Jain Hanasoge, who held a combined 4.99% stake in the company when the case was filed in March 2024.

The tribunal was informed that a new shareholder was willing to step in as a petitioner in place of Jain. The NCLT has sought responses from other

The petition alleges over ₹2,500 crore was siphoned from Jindal Poly to promoter-linked entities through undervalued asset sales and related-party deals. REUTERS

Shareholders with at least 2% in a listed

in group power companies were later

whether the landmark case can proceed at this critical juncture. With the NCLT now considering whether a new shareholder can step in as a petitioner, the development adds uncertainty.

According to lawyers, Ankit Jain's exit does not by itself weaken the class action but raises procedural concerns about whether eligible shareholders continue to represent the class.

"Ankit Jain's exit does not automatically weaken or invalidate the class action. The cause of action survives even if the original petitioner withdraws, provided the statutory thresholds for shareholder participation continue to be satisfied," said Prithiviraj Senthil Nathan, partner at King Stubb & Kasiva, Advocates and Attorneys.

Nathan said the exit primarily creates a procedural issue—whether an eligible shareholder remains to pursue the case. If not, the case's maintainability could be questioned. He also noted that any new shareholder stepping in would face scrutiny over the timing and intent of their shareholding to ensure it is bona fide and not merely strategic.

The case is being watched closely by

Food takes centre stage in Ikea India's growth strategy

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At an Ikea store in India, a shopper's journey often ends where it began—with a tray of food.

"Food is a major driver of traffic. It's among the biggest reasons customers walk into our stores," Adosh Sharma, country commercial manager at Ikea India, told *Mint*.

What started as an in-store convenience has evolved into a core lever for footfall, repeat visits and customer engagement. Now, Ikea wants to scale its food and beverage (F&B) offerings, sharpening focus on footfall-led growth and store productivity, Sharma said.

Part of this approach is to anchor visits around routine and family engagement. "It starts with kids' meals—we run 'Happy Wednesdays' where children come in and get a soft toy," Sharma said.

Menus have been localized to reflect Indian preferences. "We've created an eclectic mix of Indian and Swedish food. We realized early that retailers simply can't come in with the assump-

Low-priced items like ₹69 hot dogs and meals under ₹200 are anchoring the company's India strategy. BLOOMBERG

experience-led destinations where food is central, driving traffic, extending engagement, and strengthening store economics.

In fact, the F&B sector continues to fuel India's retail real estate growth, with its share of overall retail leasing jumping to 22% in 2025 from 16% in 2023, according to data from property consultant JLL.

The growing importance of food aligns with Ikea India's push to improve its overall business performance. The company reported a widening of its net loss to ₹1,325.2 crore

Food contributes 10% to Ikea India's business while

for a casual visit, but they almost always pick up something along the way," he said.

F&B complements this behaviour by widening the entry funnel. Customers may walk in for a meal or a quick break and end up browsing more categories, increasing the likelihood of conversion, according to Sharma.

Affordability remains central to this strategy. "For instance, we sell hot dogs for ₹69. That's the level of affordability we're trying to bring to our food," Sharma said. Low-priced packaged food like chips, candy bars, frozen meat, and beverages further encourparties on whether they had any objection to such substitution. It will also examine the legality of allowing a new shareholder to join midway through the proceedings. The next hearing has been scheduled for 30 April.

Email queries sent to Saraf and Partners, the firm representing Ankit Jain, as well as to Jindal Poly Films and Monet Securities Acquires, which purchased shares from Jain, remained unanswered at the time of publishing.

Jain's exit is a significant development in what is seen as India's first corporate class action suit under Section 245 of the Companies Act, 2013.

Section 245 allows a group of shareholders to file a single case before the NCLT if they believe a firm is acting unfairly or causing losses to investors.

firm can jointly seek action for fraud, mismanagement or wrongful conduct. The provision was introduced in 2013, following the Satyam scandal, to better protect minority shareholders.

CLASS ACTION TWIST

JAIN informed the NCLT that he sold his entire shareholding and no longer has any legal standing

A new shareholder has expressed his willingness to replace Jain as the lead petitioner

NCLT is likely to examine the legality of allowing a new petitioner to join mid-proceedings

THE case is closely being watched as a potential precedent for shareholder activism in India

The petition alleged over ₹2,500 crore was siphoned from Jindal Poly Films through undervalued asset sales and related-party transactions involving promoter-linked entities, causing losses to public and minority shareholders. It also alleged that investments sold at discounted valuations, causing significant financial damage.

The case was heard for two years before the Delhi bench of NCLT admitted it on 5 February, marking the first time an Indian tribunal formally issued notice in a class action under Section 245. The order was subsequently upheld by the NCLAT on 26 February, raising the stakes for the proceedings.

However, Jain's withdrawal creates a legal complication, casting doubt on minority investors and corporate boardrooms as its outcome could set a precedent for shareholder activism in India, where class action provisions have rarely been tested, unlike jurisdictions such as the US.

According to the petition, Jindal Poly invested about ₹703.79 crore in 2013-2017 in group power firms Jindal Powertech and Jindal India Thermal Power via preference shares. In FY21, the firms secured debt waivers of over ₹7,000 crore, which improved valuations. Shareholders alleged Jindal Poly sold these investments at deeply undervalued prices to promoter-linked entities, resulting in loss of ₹2,500 crore to investors.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

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tions that they know everything the Indian customers want."

The Swedish giant plans to deepen this localization as it scales food offerings pan-India, tailoring menu to local tastes to drive repeat visits. The scale of this shift is already visible. Food already contributes just under 10% of Ikea India's business and significantly increases dwell time (the time a customer spends in the store) by about 2 hours, according to company data.

For the broader sector, Ikea India's playbook shows how retail stores are evolving into

extending store visits by about two hours, aiding conversions

in 2024-25, while revenue from operations declined 3.33% to ₹1,749.5 crore, according to regulatory filings shared by business research platform Tofler, underscoring the need to drive higher store productivity and conversion.

Food plays a distinct role in that equation. Unlike furniture purchases, which are infrequent and high-value, food drives frequency and repeat visits, helping bring customers back into stores more often.

"I haven't seen anyone come into Ikea and leave empty-handed. People may come in

age repeat purchases.

In India, chicken meatballs are the bestseller, with sales crossing 300,000 units in 2024-25 (Sept 2025 to Aug 2025). Close to 70 food items cost under ₹200, according to Sharma.

This pricing aligns with Ikea's broader value positioning in India, where entry-level pricing is designed to encourage trial and repeat visits by customers. Even as online sales (through Ikea India's website) account for around 30% of total sales, physical stores remain central to overall experience, Sharma noted.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Why Iran thinks it won the war despite huge military losses

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When Iran agreed to a two-week cease-fire only hours before President Trump had vowed to unleash punishing new attacks, it was in many ways a moment of triumph for the battered regime.

Tehran emerged from 38 days of war against the U.S. and Israel having won not only its primary goal—its own survival—but also two potential strategic gains: control of the Strait of Hormuz and a newly

Iran's regime has survived and may possess a new strategic prize in the Strait of Hormuz. AP

Institute for Responsible Statecraft and an advocate of friendlier relations with Iran, wrote by email. "The United States is no longer in a position to dictate terms."

On Wednesday, Trump called the cease-fire a win and insisted the U.S. will retrieve Iran's enriched uranium buried under rubble. Iran wouldn't enrich uranium in the future, he said, something Tehran says it will do. He said that sanctions relief sought by Tehran was on the table but also that many of the administration's demands in

Islamabad locks down for first US-Iran talks

Israeli attacks on Lebanon kill over 250 people, threatening to torpedo Trump's truce effort

Reuters
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DUBAI/BEIRUT/ISLAMABAD

Israel bombed more targets in Lebanon on Thursday, putting the US-Iran cease-fire into further jeopardy after the biggest Israeli

established deterrence against large-scale attacks by its long-time adversaries.

Despite huge military losses, Iran's stranglehold on the vital waterway for 20% of the world's oil exports won't be broken anytime soon.

Tehran's asymmetric tactics were carefully planned to offset U.S. and Israeli military advantages, raising the pressure on Trump to halt the conflict. The cease-fire went into effect without the U.S. and Israel attaining far-reaching goals such as toppling the regime, eliminating Iran's nuclear program and ending its ability to threaten its neighbors.

"What Iran did, systematically and deliberately, was hurt the U.S. economy" by closing down Hormuz and spiking the price of oil globally, said Alex Vatanka, a senior fellow and Iran expert at the Middle East Institute. In response to Trump's effort to bring down the regime, "they made sure the war was felt in the U.S."

For that reason, he added, "I don't think Trump's going to try that again."

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The White House said it had halted offensive operations, but Iran's attacks on neighboring Arab states in the Persian Gulf hadn't stopped Wednesday, an indication that the cease-fire still faces obstacles and that it could collapse before taking hold.

Iranian officials were quick to declare victory, insisting in a statement by the country's national-security council that their longtime adversaries had suffered "an undeniable, historic, and crushing defeat." Pro-government demonstrators took to the streets after the cease-fire announcement, waving flags and chanting slogans.

Even more telling was Tehran's insistence that it would continue to assert control over Hormuz. Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi promised ships "safe passage" through the strait for two weeks during talks with the U.S. on ending the war. But he said vessels could only move "in coordination" with Iranian armed forces and "with due consideration of technical limitations."

If attacks on Iran resumed, it would restart its military operations, Araghchi warned. On Wednesday, some ships at anchor received radio messages from Iranian forces saying they still needed Iran's permission to transit the narrow strait.

The implication: Iran is intent on using its newfound control over the flow of oil from the Persian Gulf as leverage over Trump as the Islamic Republic seeks to rebuild its power after the biggest threat to its survival in decades.

Following the killing of Iran's longtime theocratic leader Ali Khamenei on the first day of the war, Iran's new leadership has taken an even more anti-Western stance, with a greater decision-making role for the hard-line Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, said analysts who study Iran.

The war has proved a disaster for Tehran in numerous respects. Its attacks on Arab countries and restrictions on their oil imports have shattered relations in the region, driving the United Arab Emirates and other Gulf countries that had cultivated ties to Iran closer to the U.S. and even to Israel.

More than five weeks of U.S. and Israeli airstrikes damaged Iran's infrastructure, including its largest petrochemical processing facility. Many of its navy ships were sunk and its large missile and drone arsenal was degraded though not fully destroyed.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said Wednesday the U.S. had achieved a "decisive military victory."

But so far, it is Trump who has appeared more conciliatory. The cease-fire would give U.S. and Iranian negotiators time to hammer out a deal, he said. A 10-point Iranian proposal calling for sweeping U.S. concessions, including a promise not to attack Iran again, lifting of all sanctions on Tehran and removal of U.S. troops from the region was "a workable basis on which to negotiate," Trump said in a social-media post.

One of 10 demands in the peace plan is the continuation of Iran's control over the strait.

"The mere fact that Iran's framework will anchor the negotiations amounts to a significant diplomatic victory for Tehran," Trita Parsi, executive vice president of the Quincy

a separate 15-point U.S. plan "have already been agreed to" by Tehran.

He also insisted that the U.S. and Iran might work jointly to oversee ship traffic through the strait. The White House played down Trump's comment that the 10-point Iranian plan would form the basis for the talks, saying he was speaking about a blueprint with different elements than those Iran has outlined publicly.

Trump could still resume airstrikes if the talks collapse. Or he could halt the war now but resume attacks in the future, or give Israel a green light to do so. For now, though, Iran is unlikely to relinquish its control over Hormuz or make other major concessions in the coming talks, analysts said.

"Any deal Trump gets now is worse than the one that was on the table when he decided to blow things up," said Alan Eyre, a former senior State Department expert on Iran and a member of the Obama administration negotiating team with Tehran. "The only question to my mind is what sort of deal Iran can work out in terms of monetizing and institutionalizing its control of the strait."

Iran's leaders have also emerged from the war seemingly even more determined to suppress internal opposition to the regime. Accused of killing thousands of protesters earlier to put down antigovernment demonstrations, the regime is taking an even harder line against opponents, accusing them of being potential spies and calling for other Iranians to report them.

Many ordinary Iranians welcomed the war when it started, encouraged by Trump's vow that help was coming. But the regime's survival, despite more than 20,000 strikes by the U.S. and Israel, have left many Iranians convinced that changing the government is even more unlikely now.

Yet the roots of the country's deep-seated domestic unrest—an economy crippled by sanctions and inflation and an unpopular theocratic government—remain, a vulnerability that even facing down the combined might of the U.S. and Israel is unlikely to eliminate.

attacks on its neighbour of the war killed more than 250 people and threatened to torpedo Donald Trump's truce.

In Pakistan, authorities locked down the capital Islamabad in anticipation of the war's first peace talks, cutting off all access to a 3km (2 mile) zone around the five-star luxury Serena Hotel. Both the US and Iranian delegations are expected to stay at the hotel, which told all guests to check out until Sunday as it had been "requisitioned" for "an important event".

But there was no sign Iran had lifted its blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, which has caused the worst disruption to global energy supplies in history. Tehran said there would be no deal as long as Israel was striking Lebanon.

The spot price that European and Asian refineries pay now for oil rose further to record levels near $150 a barrel, with even higher prices for some products such as jet fuel.

Israel, which invaded Lebanon last month in parallel with the war on Iran to root out the Iran-aligned armed group Hezbollah, says its actions there are not covered by the cease-fire announced late on Tuesday by Trump.

Washington has also said Lebanon is not covered by the truce, but Iran and Pakistan, which acted as mediator, say it was explicitly part of the deal. A host of countries, including Britain and France, said the truce should extend to Lebanon.

A Pakistani source with knowledge of the discussions said Pakistan was working on a cease-fire for Lebanon, as well as for Yemen, another country where Israel has hit Iran-aligned forces: "It will be discussed during the (upcoming) talks and we will settle it."

The Israeli military said on Thursday it had killed the nephew of Hezbollah's secretary-general Naim Qassem, who had served as his personal secretary, and struck river crossings in southern Lebanon overnight.

Israel struck Beirut's southern suburbs just before midnight and at dawn,

A family picture lies amid rubble of a building hit in an Israeli airstrike in central Beirut, Lebanon. AP

and hit towns across the south on Thursday morning, Lebanese state media said.

For its part, Hezbollah, which had initially said it would pause attacks on Israel in line with the cease-fire, said it was resuming them on Thursday morning and had fired once across the border and twice at Israeli forces in southern Lebanon.

Lebanon declared a day of national mourning and shut state offices, while rescuers worked through the night to free the wounded and the dead from under the rubble of buildings blasted apart by Israel without customary warnings to residents to flee.

Israel says its actions in Lebanon are not covered by the cease-fire announced by Trump

Outside Beirut's Rafik Hariri University Hospital, a steady stream of ambulances kept arriving throughout Thursday afternoon, driving past the emergency room entrance straight to the forensic department.

"We're picking up body parts for the most part. It's very rare that we find entire bodies intact," said a rescue worker on condition of anonymity because he was not authorised to speak to the press.

One woman, between tears, told *Reuters* she had lost her entire family in one of the strikes.

Iran's deputy foreign minister Saeed Khatibzadeh told *BBC Radio* that Israel's strikes on Lebanon were a "grave violation" of the cease-fire.

"It was a catastrophe, could actually end in more catastrophe, and this is the nature of this rogue behaviour that we are seeing from Israel in the whole Middle East."

Inside Iran, where the halt to six weeks of US and Iranian airstrikes has been portrayed as total victory for the clerical rulers, huge crowds turned out to commemorate 40 days of mourning for Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, killed on the war's first day.

State TV showed crowds in Tehran, Kermanshah, Yazd, and Zahedan, with mourners in black carrying Iranian flags and portraits of Khamenei and his son and successor Mojtaba. Large commemorative billboards were displayed and a huge Hezbollah flag hung from one building.

After six weeks of war, Trump has sought an off-ramp before the economic consequences derail his presidency.

The cease-fire has curbed a surge in energy price benchmarks, which are based on contracts to deliver oil a month in the future. But present-day spot prices paid by refineries around the world are still rising. Though Europe and Asia have been worst hit so far, the US retail price for diesel rose to $5.69 a gallon on Thursday, just 13 cents below the all-time high.

Trump, who announced the truce just before a deadline he had set to destroy Iran's "whole civilisation" unless it unblocked the strait, said on Wednesday he would resume attacks unless Iran complies: "the 'Shootin' Starts,' bigger, and better, and stronger than anyone has ever seen before".

Though Trump has declared victory, Washington has not achieved the aims he announced at the war's outset: to eliminate Iran's ability to attack its neighbours, destroy its nuclear programme or make it easier for Iranians to topple their government.

Iran still possesses missiles and drones that can hit its neighbours and a stockpile of more than 400kg (900 pounds) of uranium enriched close to the level for a weapon. Its rulers, who put down a mass uprising just months ago, survived the superpower onslaught with no sign of organised opposition.

US asks allies for plans to secure Hormuz post cease-fire

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The US wants specific commitments from European allies on their pledge to help secure the Strait of Hormuz after the fighting in Iran stops, requesting that the countries present concrete plans to ensure navigation through the waterway within days, according to a senior North Atlantic Treaty Organization (Nato) official. The request was presented during discussions between American and Nato officials at the White House — where President Donald Trump met with Nato secretary general Mark Rutte — as well as at the Pentagon and state department, according to the official. The White House, the defense department and the state department did not immediately respond to requests for comment late Wednesday night.

A UK-led coalition of more than 40 countries, which includes many European nations, Japan and Canada, has pledged to help reopen the Strait of Hormuz, through which about 20% of the world's oil and natural gas flows, after active combat in West Asia stops. The closing of the strait has sent global energy prices soaring and raised concerns about imminent fuel shortages.

Trump, Iran, and Israel announced a fragile, 14-day ceasefire agreement on Tuesday, contingent upon the cessation of attacks and the reopening of the strategic waterway. About a dozen mostly European leaders issued a statement following the accord promising they would "contribute to ensuring freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz".

However, strikes from Iran and Israel have continued and the Strait of Hormuz has remained effectively closed since the announcement. Tehran has said Israel's attacks on the Iran-aligned Hezbollah militia in Lebanon constitute a violation of the cease-fire agreement.

Why Fed rate-cut prospects have dimmed, with or without a cease-fire

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The cease-fire between the U.S. and Iran offers a chance to defuse the latest serious threat to the global economy. But for the Federal Reserve, it may have replaced one problem with another: an energy shock that lingers just enough to keep inflation elevated without being severe enough to destroy demand, leading to an extended interest-rate pause.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Minutes from the Fed's March 17-18 meeting, released Wednesday, underscored that the war hadn't created the Fed's reluctance to cut so much as it had complicated an already-cautious posture. Even before the conflict, the path to rate cuts had narrowed . The labor market had stabilized enough to ease recession fears, and progress toward the Fed's 2% inflation goal had stalled.

The Fed held its benchmark rate steady in a range between 3.5% and 3.75% at that meeting, the second consecutive pause after officials cut rates three times in the final months of 2025.

The Fed minutes said "the vast majority" of officials thought progress bringing inflation down could be slower than expected, driven by three overlapping concerns: tariff effects on goods prices that may take longer to fade, oil prices bleeding into measures of underlying inflation, and the risk that years of above-target inflation make consumers and businesses more accepting of additional price increases.

The risk that a widening conflict would drag down growth and tip the economy into a downturn had been the last, best argument for resuming rate cuts. Paradoxically, an end to the war may actually make it harder, not easier, for the Fed to ease in the short run.

That's because the cease-fire removes the worst-case economic scenario—severe price increases that disrupt supply chains and destroy demand—arguably more than it removes the risk of new inflation pressures. Energy and goods prices that rose during the conflict may not fully reverse and financial conditions, such as Wednesday's market rally, are easing on the cease-fire optimism.

Take away the risk of severe demand destruction and what's left is an inflation problem that hadn't been fully extinguished even before the recent rise in energy prices that threatens to reverberate, albeit more mildly than before, if the cease-fire holds.

"As recession odds fall, inflation odds rise as we get price pressures without as much demand destruction," said Marc Sumerlin, managing partner at economic-consulting firm Evenflow Macro.

At the same time, the cease-fire also diminishes the less likely but more disruptive prospect that a prolonged surge in energy prices would compel the Fed to consider raising rates.

Minutes from March meeting show officials continued pushing back their expectations of inflation falling toward 2% goal. REUTERS

The minutes of the March Fed meeting, released with a customary three-week delay, showed officials grappling with the prospect that the war could increase the risk of a sudden deterioration in the job market, which would call for rate cuts, while it could also increase the risk of a longer spell of elevated inflation, which would call for rate hikes.

A majority of officials continued to pencil in at least one rate cut this year in projections released after the meeting. But the minutes reinforced how those expectations were conditional on inflation resuming a decline toward their goal. The minutes said two officials had pushed back their assessment of when they thought those cuts would be justified given the absence of progress on inflation recently.

The Fed has continued to suggest in its formal postmeeting statement that its next move in rates is more likely to be down than up. But the minutes indicated that, compared to the Fed's previous meeting in January, the ranks of officials who thought they could drop that bias had grown. Changing the statement along these lines would indicate that rate increases could be appropriate if inflation continues to run too far above the Fed's target, the minutes said.

The Fed's posture reflects a compounding problem. Fed Chair Jerome Powell said last week that the Fed was confronting a fourth supply shock in recent years, following the pandemic, the Russian invasion of Ukraine, and then last year's increases in tariffs on imported goods.

The Fed has continued to suggest that its next move in rates is more likely to be down than up

He said the Fed's policy was well positioned to wait and assess the economic fallout, but he cautioned that a cascade of one-off shocks can erode the public's confidence that inflation will return to normal. That is a risk the Fed monitors closely because it believes those expectations can be self-fulfilling.

Even before the announcement of the cease-fire, current and former Fed officials have suggested that a quick resolution wouldn't necessarily mean the Fed would return immediately to business as usual. That is in part because the world has now seen how easily the Strait of Hormuz can be shut, and that vulnerability could be priced into energy markets and business planning for years to come.

Some geopolitical analysts are skeptical that the cease-fire will bring energy prices all the way back to where they were before the war. Iran has strong incentives to keep oil prices elevated in order to generate revenue to help rebuild the nation and maintain leverage over Gulf neighbors.

St. Louis Fed President Alberto Musalem last week said that even if the conflict ended in the coming weeks, he would be watching for ripple effects that keep prices elevated even after supply chains are restored. "I've been looking for the echoes...because even if the war were to end" soon, he said, "it's going to take time to bring a lot of the damaged capacity back."

The Fed's caution echoes a framework laid out more than two decades ago by then-governor Ben Bernanke, who argued that the central bank's response to an oil price shock should depend on where inflation stands when the shock hits. When inflation is already low and expectations are firmly anchored, policymakers can afford to "look through" or ignore the inflationary impulse of higher energy prices.

But when inflation is already running above target, the risk that a supply shock further dislodges expectations demands tighter policy, which some officials have suggested may be closer to the situation the Fed faces today.

6–7%

₹1,540 cr

44,787

1,000

$3 bn

NEWS IN NUMBERS

THE HIKE in UK visa fees, effective 8 April, covering most work, visitor, and settlement categories, as UK builds a streamlined digital immigration system

THE VALUE of pre-sales reported by realty firm Signature Global in Q4FY26, down 5% from ₹1,620 crore a year ago, as housing demand slowed in Gurugram

THE NUMBER of raids Punjab Police conducted under the *Gangstran Te Vaar* campaign between 20 January and 15 March, resulting in 14,894 arrests

NUMBER OF staff Walt Disney plans to lay off in the coming weeks, representing under 1% of its global workforce, the first major round under CEO Josh D. Amaro

THE VALUE of loans being syndicated by a group of banks, including Natixis, for a Meta-backed data centre in Ohio, backing the growing build-out of AI infrastructure

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Rupee settles with 3p gain at 92.51 a dollar

Investors were wary about opening of the Strait of Hormuz with Israel still attacking Lebanon. REUTERS

The rupee settled with a marginal gain of 3 paise at 92.51 against the US dollar on Thursday, backed by a weak American currency, even as the situation in West Asia remains fragile, keeping investors wary of the opening of the Strait of Hormuz. Forex traders said geopolitical uncertainty was still high amid Iran's threat to step out of the talks if Israel kept bombing Lebanon, and markets are in a wait-and-watch mode rather than strong directional positioning.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 92.63 against the US dollar and touched the intraday low of 92.92 against the greenback.

At the end of the trading session, the rupee was quoted at 92.51 against the American currency, registering a gain of 3 paise over its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee appreciated 52 paise to close at 92.54 against the US dollar after US President Donald Trump announced the suspension of military strikes against Iran for two weeks, and the Reserve Bank kept the key benchmark rate unchanged with a neutral stance. PTI

BLOOMBERG

Banks liquidate a bulk of rupee arbitrage bets

RBI had asked banks to cap net open positions in the rupee in the onshore market at $100 mn

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Banks have exited the bulk of their Indian rupee arbitrage trades to comply with central bank-imposed limits on onshore positions aimed at reining in volatility and downward pressure on the currency, three people familiar with the matter said.

The Reserve Bank of India imposed limits on banks on 27 March, directing them to cap their net open positions in the rupee in the onshore market at $100 million, requiring that they comply by Friday. The measures were aimed specifically at curbing arbitrage trades between the onshore market and the non-deliverable forward (NDF) market, according to bankers.

Arbitrage trades by banks were contributing to heightened forex market volatility, RBI chief Sanjay Malhotra said on Wednesday, noting that the central bank had seen increased price swings in recent weeks. Estimates of the arbitrage positions varied widely when the measures were introduced, though market participants have since settled on a figure of roughly $40 billion, two of the people familiar with the matter said, requesting anonymity because they were not authorised to discuss the matter publicly.

Most of these positions have been unwound, with no extension likely for banks, a person familiar with the central bank's thinking said, asking not to be identified since they are not authorized to speak with the media.

RBI did not immediately reply to an email seeking comment.

Thursday's price action, suggested that most arbitrage positions had already been unwound, with the rupee weakening and forward premiums rising—the opposite of what would be expected during heavy unwinding.

The rupee slipped 0.2% to 92.77 per US dollar, set to halt a four-day rise, while one-year forward premiums climbed 12 basis points to 3.12% after dropping more than 50 basis points over the past three sessions. A currency trader at a private sector bank said most positions at his bank had already been exited, and that public sector banks, which had begun unwinding later, have done their exits over the past two days.

VW group eyes 5% India market share

German auto major Volkswagen group is targeting 5% market share in the Indian passenger vehicles market before the turn of the decade with alternative fuel technologies slated to play a key role in achieving the target, a senior company official said on Thursday. The group, which in 2018 announced its India 2.0 strategy led by group brand Skoda had set a target to achieve 5% market share by 2025 but missed it due to events such as covid-19 pandemic, currently has about 2.5% share in India.

"In the last two or three years as we have evaluated, our medium term aspiration is definitely to go to 5% market share. We are little below 2.5% now...and we would definitely need product interventions to reach 5% and that is what we are working on," Skoda Auto Volkswagen India MD & CEO Piyush Arora told reporters in New Delhi. PTI

Royal Enfield's Flying Flea C6 marks the firm's first step into electric motorcycling.

Royal Enfield enters electric bike market

Eicher Motors Ltd group firm Royal Enfield on Thursday announced its foray into the electric motorcycle segment with the launch of Flying Flea C6 bike. Flying Flea is the new "city+ electric mobility" brand from Royal Enfield. The Flying Flea C6 (FF.C6) is priced at ₹2.79 lakh (ex-showroom) and ₹1.99 lakh with battery-as-a-service option, Eicher Motors said in a regulatory filing.

Eicher Motors managing director and chief executive officer-Royal Enfield, B. Govindarajan, said the introduction of the Flying Flea C6 marks the company's "first step into electric motorcycling in our 125th year—a milestone that reflects both our legacy and our intent for new beginnings".

"This is not just about going electric, it is about creating a new category of urban mobility that is rooted in experience," he added. PTI

Granules to tighten checks as FDA flags

Granules India is increasing oversight at its manufacturing facilities and digitizing documents after the US drug regulator flagged violations, including issues with record-keeping and contamination control practices, at its largest plant, a top executive said. The company, which is globally one of the largest paracetamol makers and a major player in the active pharmaceutical ingredients market, derives a bulk of its revenue from the US.

Last year, the Food and Drug Administration flagged violations in good manufacturing practices, equipment cleaning and contamination controls at the company's plant in Telangana. REUTERS

The Nifty 50 fell 0.93% to 23,775.1 and the Sensex shed 1.2% to 76,631.65 on Thursday. REUTERS

Indian stocks retreat on fragility of truce

Indian shares fell on Thursday, pulling back after a sharp rally in the previous session, as renewed West Asia tensions cooled hopes of the Iran-U.S. ceasefire leading to lasting peace.

The Nifty 50 fell 0.93% to 23,775.1 and the Sensex shed 1.2% to 76,631.65.

Ten of the 16 major sectors declined, while mid-caps and small-caps rose 0.3% and 0.2%, respectively.

Financials fell 1.4% after the sub-index jumped 5.5% in the previous session. HDFC Bank and ICICI Bank were down 2.3% and 2.1%, respectively on the day.

India's top software services firm TCS rose 1.2% ahead of its of earnings report later in the day.

It led the IT index up 0.2%, while concerns over rising artificial intelligence disruption risks after U.S. firm Anthropic launched its Mythos model capped gains.

Recruitment services firm Info Edge lost 2.9% after reporting a slower growth in billings for the March quarter compared with October-December.

Metal stocks bucked the trend and rose 1.3%, led by a 3.6% and a 2.2% rise in aluminium makers Hindalco and Vedanta. PTI

GAIL to borrow up to ₹6,000 cr in FY27

India's largest gas distributor GAIL (India) plans to borrow ₹5,0000–6,000 crore in fiscal 2027 to fund expansion, and has bought three spot LNG cargoes to offset supply shortages caused by the Iran war, a company executive said on Thursday. The amount it plans to borrow would be the equivalent of $539 million–$647 million. Finance director Rakesh Jain, at an industry event, also said GAIL's Dabhol LNG import terminal in Ratnagiri, Maharashtra state, is handling 2.25 million tonnes per year, below its 5 million tpy capacity, due to tighter global supplies. Iran's blocking of the Strait of Hormuz, which handles 20% of global LNG flows, have slashed availability and pushed up spot prices. PTI

Tata Steel CEO flags new challenges

India's diversification of energy sources and enhancing access to critical minerals are crucial for the country's economy, but this shift has introduced new challenges, Tata Steel CEO and managing director T. V. Narendran said on Thursday. Addressing All India Management Association's (AIMA's) Leadership Conclave, Narendran termed India's energy and critical minerals diversification move as a "layered vulnerability". "The challenge is obvious while we are diversifying our sources of energy and critical minerals, and we must; this diversification is also a layered vulnerability, not just dependence on imports but also dependence on political goodwill that allows these imports to flow," he said. Narendran, who is also the AIMA president, said, "The opportunity for India is not only to make itself but also to sell to the world. The real test is to be good enough to be able to do that," he said. PTI

Centre considers community kitchens for migrant workers

FROM PAGE 1

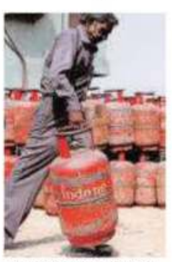
ply of gas cylinders without registered connections.

At the meeting, the government assured immediate intervention at different levels to protect MSMEs, and said a relief package is expected to be cleared by the Union Cabinet shortly, said one of the two people cited above.

Clusters identified as 'vulnerable' include the ceramics and tiles hub in Morbi in Gujarat, the forging and textiles clusters in Ludhiana, Punjab, the textile manufacturing and export hub in Tiruppur, Tamil Nadu, the textile processing clusters in Surat, Gujarat, and the glass manufacturing cluster in Firozabad in Uttar Pradesh.

This assumes significance given that the MSME sector contributes about 30.1% to India's GDP and accounts for 35.4% of its manufacturing output and nearly 45% of the country's export.

"The plan is to extend community kitchen services, which are already in operation in several states, to the manufacturing clusters. It may also include setting up new community kitchens with the cooperation of state governments, as well as industry and social groups," said the sec-



The kitchens will get assured cooking gas supply. MINT

Queries sent to the spokespersons of the ministries of finance and MSME remained unanswered until press time.

To be sure, several states run subsidized community kitchen or low-cost meal schemes for workers and the urban poor. Tamil Nadu operates the 'Amma Unavagam', while Karnataka runs 'Indira Canteens', offering meals at nominal rates. Odisha has 'Aahar Centres' and Andhra Pradesh runs the 'Anna Canteen' scheme. Madhya Pradesh provides meals under 'Deendayal Antyodaya Rasoi Yojana', while Maharashtra operates the 'Shiv Bhojan Thali'. Rajasthan also runs a

mainly operational in cities, and provide a meal for ₹5–10, supporting migrant workers and low-income groups.

Hailing the move, industry leaders said it is a well thought-out step to ensure availability of workers at India's manufacturing clusters.

"If the government is considering a proposal to provide food to workers at affordable rates at the manufacturing clusters, it will certainly help the industry and allow units to remain operational even during crisis periods," said Nilesh Jetpariya, chairman (ceramic panel) at the Chemical and Allied Products Export Promotion Council. "If needed, the industry will also support the government."

He also sought support for the industries. "The government should also intervene in ensuring the supply of gas, which is a key raw material for the manufacture of ceramic products. We would like to draw government's attention to two key requirements: first, the availability of 75-80 lakh (750-800 million) cubic metres of gas from Gujarat Gas. And second, a uniform and reasonable price for all factories in the range of ₹55-60 per cubic metre," Jetpariya added.

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Govt to bar private lab tests of vaccines, biological products

FROM PAGE 1

sector, there are 350 to 400 standalone laboratories approved to test drugs and raw materials, according to the CDSCO's Sugam portal. However, only a small, specialized fraction has the high-level biosafety certification required to test vaccines and biologics.

In fiscal year 2025 (FY25), a total of 116,323 drug samples were tested, of which 3,104 samples were declared Not of Standard Quality (NSQ), and 245 were found to be spurious and adulterated, government data showed.

The Serum Institute of India is the world's largest vaccine manufacturer by number of doses produced and sold. Other major vaccine producers include Bharat Biotech, Biological E and Zydus Lifesciences. In the biopharma and biosimilars segment, Biocon Biologics, Dr. Reddy's Laboratories and Lupin are the key producers of complex monoclonal antibodies and therapeutic proteins.

Queries emailed to the spokespersons of the health and family welfare ministry, the Drugs Controller General of India, Dr. Reddy's and Zydus Lifesciences remained unanswered till press time. Serum Institute of India, Biocon, Bharat Biotech and Lupin declined to comment.

Dr Vikram Paradkar, executive

In FY25, 3,104 drug samples were NSQ, 245 spurious. BLOOMBERG

is tested at its own quality control facilities and submitted to the National Control Laboratory at Kasauli for testing and release. "Thus, there is no change to existing practice and Biological E. Limited manufacturing sites possess necessary internal infrastructure to conduct all the required testing," he said.

According to the document reviewed by *Mint*, the quality of biological products has a direct impact on public health and immunization programmes. Consequently, it is essential to assure the consistent quality of each lot before it is released in the market.

Biologics including monoclonal antibodies (lab-made proteins that

Biologics are medicines that are made from living systems such as microorganisms and plant or animal cells and not chemically synthesized.

"Keeping in view the nature of these specialized products, the PTL (private testing labs) may be restricted for testing of non-biological products only on behalf of the licensed manufacturer as per rules," according to the government document.

The Indian biopharmaceutical market is valued at $12 billion, with the vaccine market valued at $5.19 billion and monoclonal antibodies at $8.2 billion, according to Invest India and market research reports.

Dr. Rajeev Jayadevan, a public health expert, said unlike common medications like paracetamol, biological products are increasingly used in the prevention and treatment of diseases including cancer, heart disease, stroke, arthritis and infections and their testing needs to be extremely rigorous.

"Biologicals are much larger molecules that frequently require living cells in highly controlled environments to produce," Jayadevan said. "Any variation in their quality can potentially lead to major consequences. So, their testing has to be stringent. India's position as the 'pharmacy of the world' brings with it not just opportunity, but responsibility—particularly in

Adani Green arm in pact with UAE firm

Adani Green Energy on Thursday said its subsidiary Adani Renewable Energy Middle East Ltd (AGEL UAE) has signed a joint venture agreement with Minerva Holding RSC to develop renewable energy projects in India. According to a regulatory filing, EPointZero Holding RSC Ltd (EPointZero), the energy and infrastructure arm of International Holding Co. PJSC (IHC Group), has entered in a joint venture with Adani Green Energy Ltd for the development, construction and operation of renewable energy projects, which the JV intends to develop in India.

Minerva is wholly owned by EPointZero.

IHC Group is the largest listed company in the UAE with a market capitalization of over $230 billion. Under the pact, AGEL UAE will acquire up to 20% stake in the joint venture Minerva Renewables Holding RSC. Minerva will have the ondperson, adding that it would be initiated with the provision of three meals a day.

similar initiative through the 'Jan Aahar Yojana'.
These state schemes are

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vice president – vaccines at Biological E, said in an email that every single batch of the company's vaccines

act like human antibodies) and hormones are tested at the National Institute of Biologicals in Noida.

the production and testing of increasingly complex biological products."

right to appoint up to four directors, and Adani Green Energy will have the right to appoint one director.
PTI

SECOND LIFE: RMG OUTFITS TRY NEW PLAYING FIELDS

Six months after real-money gaming was banned, the industry is trying to reboot.

Radhika P. Nair
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CHENNAI

Before the real money gaming ban, 95% of our revenue came from Dream11, and 100% of the profits. Now, we are just using yesteryear profits as cash," says Harsh Jain, chief executive of Dream Sports.

Six months since the government ban took effect in October last year, the companies that once collectively handled thousands of crores in transactions are in disarray. Many have shut down, some are dealing with ongoing enforcement actions, and a handful have pivoted, attempting to rebuild across categories such as stockbroking, microdramas and free-to-play games. But so far, none has matched what was lost.

India's gaming industry was estimated to be worth around $6 billion in 2024-25, according to consulting firm Redseer, with real money (RMG) contributing roughly 71% of total revenue.

The sector was dominated by a handful of players, such as Dream11, Games24x7, Gameskraft, Mobile Premier League, Zupee, WinZO and PokerBaazi, who offered real-money formats such as fantasy sports, rummy and poker. Dream11 had over 250 million users, while WinZO had over 200 million, Zupee over 150 million, and Games24x7 about 120 million.

The sector had also attracted significant investor interest, with Tiger Global, Peak XV Partners, DST Global, Falcon Edge, Matrix Partners and WestCap Group among the backers. Over the past five years, global investors had poured in at least $2.8 billion into India's RMG market, backing rapid user growth and strong monetization.

All of that came to a grinding halt when the Indian government passed the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025, effectively outlawing formats that involved entry fees and cash rewards.

Before the ban, the model was straightforward. Users paid entry fees to participate in contests or games, a portion of which was redistributed as winnings, while the platform retained a commission of around 10-20%.

"If you look at the Indian gaming industry over the last decade, what really monetized was real-money gaming," says Nitish Mittersain, managing director of Nazara Technologies, which had exposure to RMG through its investment in Moonshine Technology, the parent company of PokerBaazi. He added that in RMG the conversion rate of paying users as a percentage of overall users was around 15%, while it is around 0.5% for games that rely on in-app purchases.

It is this monetization element that made RMG the dominant part of Indian gaming.

However, even before the ban, regulatory pressure had been building. A long-running dispute over how online gaming should be taxed remains before the Supreme Court. The government has argued that platforms should pay 28% goods and services tax (GST) on the full value of deposits, rather than on the platform fee they retain. Companies have challenged this interpretation, particularly its retrospective application, which could expose the industry to liabilities estimated at ₹2–2.5 trillion.

At the same time, enforcement actions have intensified scrutiny. Companies

TARUN KUMAR SAHU/MINT

Before the ban, fantasy sports was not just the company's largest business, it was effectively its only meaningful source of revenue. That business had scaled significantly. The company reported consolidated revenue of 7,374 crore in 2024-25, with gross gaming revenue, or platform fees collected from users, at ₹10,284

The early signals are promising. The company saw around 25 million users during the T20 World Cup and is targeting 50 million during the ongoing IPL season, though Jain cautioned that the behaviour is still nascent.

Other verticals include sports travel platform DreamSetGo and its sports

"It took us almost 13 years to reach that level," says Singh, adding that the company is also exploring international markets. "Now we have to go and do the grind again from scratch."

If PokerBaazi reflects a product-first rebuild, Nazara Technologies represents a more insulated bet that still faced the

PokerBaazi's parent for ₹832 crore in September 2024. However, it did not consolidate revenue, treating the investment as what Mittersain described as an "option value".

Following the ban, the company wrote down its investment, taking a one-time impairment that pushed it into a net loss of over ₹900 crore in the second quarter of 2025-26. It remains an investor in PokerBaazi.

For others, the transition has been more chaotic. Zupee is experimenting across multiple categories, including microdramas, astrology and free-to-play games.

However, an employee described the current phase as one where the company is trying multiple approaches without a clear long-term direction. "We don't know if any of these verticals will scale, or even be viable in the long term," he says.

The company declined to respond to requests for official comment.

While the new formats have brought in users, something is still missing: money.

MONETISATION ISSUE

For companies such as Dream11, the shift has meant building products where engagement does not automatically translate into revenue. The watch-along model, for instance, is designed to drive interaction through creators, community features and second-screen behaviour, but monetisation depends on advertising, virtual gifting and in-app purchases, all of which require scale and sustained user engagement over time.

"Real-money gaming had a very different monetisation profile. Now, you are dependent on scale, retention and time spent," says Jain.

At PokerBaazi, the shift has required rethinking how users are monetised altogether. The company's subscription model reflects one such attempt, but it requires users to see value in gameplay and experience rather than the possibility of winning money.

At Zupee, the company is also trying subscriptions for ad-free games and unlimited access to its micro dramas. The company acquired AI startup Nucanon last November for AI-based storytelling, and has reportedly acquired Mumbai-based microdrama startup Vertical TV.

While the shows and free games have found early takers, the scale is still small.

Since the ban, the company's revenue has plunged, reflecting the difficulty of replacing real-money formats with engagement-driven products.

THE PRODUCT GAP

Beyond monetisation, the transition away from RMG has exposed a deeper structural gap in how products are built.

"Real-money gaming masked the

mint KEY NUMBERS

71%

The estimated contribution of the real money gaming segment to India's total $6 billion gaming revenue, according to Redseer.

₹10,284 CRORE

Dream11's gross gaming revenue, or platform fees collected from users, in FY25. It underlines the company's scale pre-ban.

₹2.5 TRILLION

The total potential retrospective tax liability facing the industry. Companies have challenged the government's interpretation.

engagement.

PokerBaazi's Singh agrees. "When there is no money to be made, and it is purely for entertainment, you need to build a lot of recreational features to keep them engaged," he says.

Singh added that the company has introduced features such as in-game interactions, content integrations such as "poker TV", and private tables for social play. "We are competing with the likes of Netflix because users have limited time and have to choose between casual gaming, OTT or Instagram."

Apart from direct money incentives, RMG companies were also heavily spending on marketing to acquire and retain users at scale. In 2024-25, for instance, Dream11's marketing expenses crossed ₹3,900 crore, while PokerBaazi spent over ₹460 crore. Zupee's outgo exceeded ₹800 crore in 2023-24, according to data from Tracxn. The company has not disclosed its 2024-25 numbers yet.

These companies are now trying out frugality. "We did everything we could to cut down expenses," says Jain, adding that Dream Sports cut back on marketing, advertising and consulting spends, and even moved offices to reduce rental costs by roughly 30%. "Now, our only expense is on people."

But it has been tough to keep employees who were used to a different type of scale and growth motivated.

"As founders, we have to make sure we keep the team as aligned as possible and show them what the next phase of growth looks like," says Singh. "This is the biggest struggle right now, to keep the team together and prepare for that."

WHAT NEXT

The RMG ban may have removed a significant chunk of revenue from the gaming industry, but insiders say this was necessary for the health of the overall industry.

IGPDA's Gondal says the pivots away from RMG were necessary. "These pivots force companies to build real games, real engagement, and real communities instead of relying on transactional mechanics. Not every company will survive this transition, but that is healthy," he adds.

India still has a large base of gamers. But it is still not clear what type of games will make them open their wallets.

"You cannot ignore the fact that India has 500 million gamers," says Nazara's Mittersain. "The opportunity is still very large, but the question is what kind of products will be able to capture that opportunity."

such as Gameskraft and WinZO have faced investigations into alleged financial irregularities, including money laundering, with their bank accounts being frozen, while others have secured interim relief.

Against this backdrop, even the largest companies are being forced to rebuild from scratch, betting that the user base they built through real-money gaming will follow them into new formats.

> The presence of money had created a built-in incentive for users to participate. That reduced need for companies to invest in gameplay depth and content ecosystems

STARTING OVER

"The base has to reset to basically zero. Whatever capital you have is basically what you're worth today," says Jain, describing the position not just of Dream Sports, but of the industry at large.

crore. It had been consistently profitable from 2019-20 through 2023-24, before reporting a loss of ₹479 crore in 2024-25, largely due to one-time tax and Esop-related costs rather than a deterioration in the underlying business.

What has followed is a rapid restructuring of the company into multiple parallel bets.

"We are essentially behaving like a portfolio of startups now," Jain says, adding that each business has been given a runway of 18 to 24 months as the company deploys past profits to build new verticals.

Dream Sports' most visible bet is its watch-along product, which allows users to join live streams during matches, interact with creators, and engage socially while watching games.

streaming and commerce business Fancode, as well as newer bets such as Dream Money, an AI-led wealth management product, and Dream Street, a stockbroking platform that the company plans to launch by the end of this month.

At PokerBaazi, the reset has been more direct. "It took a couple of days to just digest what had happened," says co-founder Puneet Singh. "Then it was back to the drawing board."

The company has since pivoted to a non-real-money version of poker, and more broadly to casual gaming. It took the team a couple of months to revamp the product as it moved from monetary incentives to an engagement-driven model.

PokerBaazi, which laid off around 270 employees, has moved to a subscription-led model, priced at roughly ₹400 a month, alongside in-app purchases. The company reported revenue of ₹530 crore in 2024-25.

impact of regulatory shifts.

Nazara, which publicly listed in 2021, had historically stayed away from real-money formats, focusing instead on esports, casual gaming and global acquisitions. "We were taking a generally conservative view on not operating in regulatory grey areas. But real-money gaming companies kept becoming bigger," says Mittersain.

In 2023, the government clarified how GST would be applied to RMG. For Nazara, this appeared to signal a move towards clearer regulation.

"We felt that if the direction was towards positive regulation, we may miss the boat completely. That's why in 2024 we took the call to invest a large amount in PokerBaazi, because they were market leaders and we felt that if this played out well, they could create immense value for our shareholders," says Mittersain.

Nazara acquired a 47.7% stake in

lack of original Indian IP and deep game-making capability. The ecosystem became overly dependent on incentives and payouts rather than storytelling, design quality, and gameplay," says Vishal Gondal, founder of Indiagames, among the country's first gaming companies.

He is currently co-chair of the Indian Game Publishers and Developers Association (IGPDA). "With RMG out of the picture, India has the opportunity to reset and focus on building real games made in India, rooted in Indian culture, and capable of competing globally."

For much of the past decade, the presence of money created a built-in incentive for users to participate, spend and return. That reduced the need for companies to invest heavily in gameplay depth, content ecosystems or community-driven

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However, Dream Sports' Jain says these questions are moot until the Supreme Court delivers its verdict to settle the long-running dispute over the taxation of online gaming. Given the high stakes, with total potential exposure for the industry estimated at ₹2–2.5 trillion, companies are worried.

Jain says the unresolved tax issue has been hanging over the industry like Damocles' sword.

"If the verdict is against us, the industry will obviously go through an existential crisis because that sum was not even payable when we had our old business running. Now, it's impossible because that business has shut."

If the verdict is favourable, it could ease the immediate financial overhang on the industry. But the larger challenge of rebuilding a viable business without real-money gaming will remain.

Early SIF returns are encouraging, but investors must stay cautious

SIFs slightly outperformed mutual funds during the West Asia war-led correction amid FPI selling, high valuations

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At least three new fund offers (NFOs) announced in April under the specialized investment fund (SIF) framework, introduced by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) in 2025, will add to a sharp surge in assets under management (AUM) of these products.

The net AUM of this category, that is the total market value of all investments a fund manages including inflows, outflows and changes in asset prices on a given date, have risen from ₹2,010.44 crore at the end of October 2025 (when the Association of Mutual Funds in India released SIF numbers after first launch in September) to ₹9,710.87 crore at the end of February.

These will also give investors a variety of options in the category, which was dominated by hybrid long-short strategies that use equities, debt, and derivatives to balance risk and returns during the initial phase.

Unlike a mutual fund that takes only long positions, buying and holding stocks to benefit when prices rise, SIFs can employ both long and short strategies. In other words, SIFs are not dependent only on upward market movement and can also generate returns in a bearish market. By using derivatives, they can profit even when prices fall.

Mint spoke to industry players to assess target users and performance.

Early performance as a metric?

The early picture shows that these funds have performed slightly better than mutual funds when the Nifty 500 fell around 14% from 1 January-31 March as the West Asia war escalated at the end of February on top of the constant selling by foreign investors amid high valuations.

According to Value Research data, hybrid long-short funds, where most of the current AUM is concentrated, delivered an average negative three-month return of 3.1% as of 31 March.

During the same period (1 January-31 March), their benchmark, the Nifty 50 Hybrid Composite Debt 50:50 Index fell 7.8%. For comparison, traditional mutual funds that invest in both equities and debt to balance risk and return, like balanced advantage schemes, had average negative return of 8.1%. Equity savings saw an average negative return of 3.5%, while arbitrage schemes delivered an average return of 1.5% at the end of March.

In equity-oriented SIFs, only three schemes launched before 1 January delivered a negative three-month return of 10.1%, compared to the Nifty 500 Total Return Index's -13.9% return from 1 January to 31 March.

During this period, flexi-cap long-only mutual funds posted an average negative return of 13.1%.

But experts advise waiting for at

SIFs hold up better during drawdowns

Early comparisons suggest specialized investment funds (SIFs) may cushion drawdowns better than some mutual funds but may lag in strong bull markets.

Returns calculated for the three-month period from 1 January to 31 March across seven SIFs launched until December.
Note: SIFs are relatively new products, making it difficult to draw firm conclusions about performance.
The graphic captures early trends in a volatile market phase.

SIF assets gather momentum

Assets under management (AUM) across SIFs

	Net AUM (in ₹ crore)	Number of schemes (cumulative)	Number of folios
Oct 2025	2,010	4	10,212
Nov 2025	2,932	5	14,712
Dec 2025	4,892	7	20,779
Jan 2026	6,564	8	24,372
Feb 2026	9,711	11	39,851

Net AUM represents the total market value of assets managed by funds, including inflows, outflows, and changes in asset prices at a given point in time.
Data source: Value Research, Amfi, NSE

How SIFs differ from mutual funds

SIFs	Mutual funds
Limited track record; many strategies based on back-tested models	Established track record
Long-short strategies allowed	Long-only investing
Greater portfolio flexibility	Simpler structure and higher transparency
Limited liquidity in some structures	High liquidity
Potential downside protection	Stronger performance in bull markets
Minimum investment ₹10 lakh	Minimum investment as low as ₹100–500

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Advisors, said the launch of these products has coincided with a sharp correction in equity markets. While they have shown some downside protection, they are likely to underperform in a one-way bull market.

Feroze Azeez, joint chief executive, Anand Rathi Wealth Ltd, also noted that there is very limited data to judge performance, most SIFs have been in existence for less than a year, and early NAVs are broadly around the launch price, signalling that it is too soon to look at their performance. "Since SIFs use long-short and derivatives strategies, performance needs to be seen across at least one full market cycle," he said. By then, there will also be more schemes and better comparability, he added.

The new category opens room for innovation for asset management

imum ticket size of ₹10 lakh.

Structurally different from MF

This product was launched to bridge the gap between mutual funds and portfolio management services (PMS) in terms of portfolio flexibility. SIFs can invest in both long and short strategies. From a structural perspective, Azeez said investors should be aware that while Sebi allows up to 25% short exposure, there is no minimum requirement, so a long-short fund can still behave largely like a long-only fund.

He added that these may also come with restricted redemption windows, lock-ins, or interval structures, resulting in lower liquidity compared to mutual funds.

Sandeep Tandon, founder and chief investment officer, of Quant Mutual Fund, said they have utilized

tive and investors should evaluate it over a three-to-five-year horizon.

Bhavesh Jain, co-head of factor investing at Edelweiss Mutual Fund explained that performance in the hybrid category has varied because each fund follows a different strategy. He said the Altiva Hybrid long-short fund has shown only a minor decline in performance during January-March, as its positioning as an arbitrage-plus fund and a disciplined approach to avoiding equity chasing have given it the flexibility to cut down equity exposure.

Jain clarified that the fund's derivatives exposure has been 14-15%, and that special situations such as initial public offerings and demergers have also contributed to alpha generation.

Unlike traditional open-ended mutual funds, where you can invest

structure, in which subscriptions are allowed daily, but redemptions are restricted to two days per week.

This structure enables fund managers to manage derivatives positions, arbitrage books and fixed-income allocation without the pressure of daily redemption outflows. Some funds may also have a notice period of up to 15 working days. SIF disclosures are less transparent, making it harder to track, so the framework is evolving, but not fully mature yet, Azeez said.

Who can consider investing?

SIFs are better positioned than traditional long-only mutual funds, as their taxation is similar to that of a mutual fund and their fund managers have been given greater flexibility, said Sandeep Seth, founder and CEO of SIF360. He added that it is also for that class of investors who were not ready to count on a single fund manager for minimum investment of ₹50 lakh and ₹1 crore through other vehicles.

"We are not recommending trying SIFs to beginners, those with less time horizon, and have total investment of less than ₹30-40 lakh," he said.

Dhawan also said this product is for those who are comfortable with buying into strategies that don't have a long track record. Investors can allocate a small portion of their capital, mindful that what they are buying into is mostly through a back-tested model and the real data is limited. It is also for investors who are looking to diversify from long-only products.

According to him, for a new category, the allocation as a percentage of the portfolio should not go beyond 10% at the most. He added that until the track record of these funds exists, investors should look at the expense ratio and the track record of the fund management team in short strategies, because the skill set available here is relatively limited compared to long-only products.

He said one advice is that investors should run an overall concentrated portfolio, but because SIFs are new products, they should consider being a little more.

New launches

As of early April, three new SIFs are expected to launch this month, including Franklin Templeton's Sapphire and The Wealth Company's WSIF equity long-short funds and Quant qSIF's active asset allocator long-short fund.

Ultimately, SIFs are more flexible than mutual funds and more accessible than AIFs, but the category is still in its infancy. Their early outperformance during a downturn is encouraging, not conclusive. Patience, modest allocation, and close attention to fund manager quality will matter far more than chasing the early winners.

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POWER POINT

SANJEEV GOVILA

Respond to this column at feedback@livemint.com

MARKETS PRICE IN UNCERTAINTY, NOT JUST THE CONFLICT

Markets rattle when war breaks out. Investors fear uncertainty more than the conflict itself. Recent developments, including the temporary ceasefire in West Asia, show how quickly sentiment shifts once escalation risks ease.

Why markets react sharply to geopolitical crises

When geopolitical tensions rise, investors ask: Could the conflict spiral into something bigger? Such fears are not irrational. History shows that while wars and geopolitical rivalries unsettle markets, they rarely derail long-term wealth creation.

During the Gulf War in 1990, global equity markets fell when Iraq invaded Kuwait and oil prices surged. Yet markets recovered within months once it was clear the conflict would be contained. During the Iraq war in 2003, markets fell in the months leading up to the conflict. Once the war started and uncertainty eased, equities rebounded. Markets often react sharply at the onset of a conflict and the biggest risk lies in how events might escalate.

The uncertainty discount

When geopolitical risks intensify, markets price in worst-case scenarios. Investors demand higher risk premiums and asset prices adjust accordingly, creating an 'uncertainty discount'. The recent cooling of oil prices and recovery in equities shows how quickly this discount can unwind as worst-case fears recede.

Investors with a long-term perspective can use such phases to build positions in fundamentally strong businesses. When uncertainty fades, markets often recover faster than expected. The key lesson is not predicting geopolitical outcomes but recognizing that markets often overreact in the short run.

Why oil matters

While global markets may recover from geopolitical tensions, India faces a specific vulnerability: dependence on crude oil imports. Recent volatility in crude prices amid the West Asia war shows how quickly the risks can materialize. India imports over 80% of oil needs, so disruptions in global markets significantly affect the economy. A sharp rise in crude prices affects inflation, widens current account deficit and impacts the rupee. Higher oil prices influence interest rates and government finances. When inflation rises due to elevated energy costs, central banks may keep monetary conditions tighter for longer, raising borrowing costs across the economy.

> Investors can use such phases to build positions in strong businesses

For investors, macroeconomic linkages matter. Rising oil prices influence sectoral performance in equity markets. Energy-intensive industries may face margin pressure, while oil-producing and energy-related businesses could benefit. Understanding these dynamics helps investors interpret volatility more rationally rather than reacting emotionally to geopolitical headlines.

Discipline, diversification and perspective

Geopolitical tensions test investors' emotional resilience. Volatility often triggers impulsive decisions such as panic selling or abandoning long-term strategies. Yet successful investing rarely depends on predicting geopolitical events. Instead, it depends on building portfolios resilient enough to withstand uncertainty.

Diversification across sectors, asset classes and geographies helps reduce the impact of sudden shocks. The philosophy of 'buy right and sit tight' remains relevant for long-term investors. Short-term volatility may be uncomfortable, but it is an inherent feature of equity investing.

Staying focused through uncertainty

Conflicts may disrupt supply chains, influence commodity prices and trigger temporary corrections. Yet history shows markets adapt quickly when uncertainty begins to fade. The current easing of tensions may offer relief but also shows how quickly sentiment can reverse if uncertainty resurfaces. For investors, the real challenge is not avoiding volatility but maintaining discipline during uncertainty. Those who remain patient, diversified and focused on long-term fundamentals are often best positioned when stability returns.

Geopolitical conflicts may shake markets in the short term, as recent events show. But disciplined investors recognise that uncertainty eventually subsides and that long-term success least a full market cycle to gauge their performance. Vishal Dhawan, a certified financial planner and co-founder of Plan Ahead Wealth

companies, which were earlier limited to one scheme per category. Under the SIF framework, they can now launch seven additional strategies with a min-

only between 9-12% of the 25% short limit allowed under the framework. He added that the category is designed with a longer-term perspec-

or redeem on any business day at the applicable net asset value (NAV), the hybrid strategies under the SIF framework operate in an interval

an extended version of this story.

depends less on predicting crises and more on staying invested through them.

Col (retd) Sanjeev Govila is a certified financial planner and CEO of Hum Fauji Initiatives, a financial advisory firm.

'Ignore war headlines, focus on fundamentals for long-term wealth'

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MUMBAI

PPFAS Mutual Fund used March's market turbulence to its advantage, finding opportunities to deploy cash, according to chief investment officer Rajeev Thakkar. Speaking as part of the Mint Money Guru series, Thakkar explained why war and ceasefire headlines matter little for long-term investing and how he is approaching equities in the current environment.

MONEY GURU

How did you navigate March's volatility, and what key portfolio change did you make?

We tell investors that if they want to invest for one year or less, they should put their money in liquid funds, arbitrage funds, or money market funds, all suitable for short-term investments. For people with money for three to four years, we suggest hybrid funds that combine equity and debt. We ask them to invest only in pure equity funds if they have money for a period of more than five years. For anyone with a longer-term time horizon, all these things even out. Be it war, inflation, interest rates, lower GDP (gross domestic product) growth, or currency movement, they mean-revert over a period of time. Our focus has been on management quality, earning visibility, balance sheet strength, pricing power, and valuations. So, we have been using volatility to our advantage, deploying wherever we find opportunities and selling wherever the opportunity comes.

Has the announcement of the two-week truce changed how you are looking at certain segments of the equity market?

Not really. Some pre-existing trends in the business world might accelerate a bit because of this. The world has been moving away from fossil fuels towards renewables, including solar, wind and nuclear for primary energy as well as for transportation, where people have been trying to electrify. That trend will gain importance not only from an environmental perspective but also for energy security. You don't want some external event to bring your country to a grinding halt. So, those trends might accelerate a bit, but otherwise, not much changes.

Would you say that the current 20% of flexi-cap AUM held in cash at the end of February is usual for PPFAS? Did you get an opportunity to deploy in March?

It is not usual. For the last two years, we have been a bit cautious about the market given valuations. In this period, we have seen time corrections and, in some cases, price corrections as well. Small- and mid-cap stocks have corrected, and earnings have had time to catch up. Given all of that, valuations are more reasonable now, and opportunities are emerging. The cash gave us the opportunity to buy during a sell-off in March. But the cash percentages vary; if you start with a 20% allocation to money market and cash securities, 80% is in stocks. If the market falls 10%, that becomes 72%. So, optically, in terms of percentage, cash looks higher; even if you deploy money, it seems as if cash has not come down. But we opportunistically deployed some money last month. At the end of March, our flexi-cap fund held 18.94% in cash.

Before the war began, markets were already falling due to valuation concerns and persistent selling by foreign portfolio investors. Do these concerns still remain?

To an extent. India has been an outlier in terms of valuations in the emerging market space. Emerging economies such as China and South Korea had not done well for quite some time, but this has changed due to the peculiar nature of industries in various markets that are in an upcycle, such as electronics manufacturing, chips, and memory units. So, low starting valuations as well as higher earnings growth have made them a bit more attractive for emerging managers. FPIs have been sellers, but given the time, the price correction, and somewhat of a return to normalcy in Indian markets, I think it will become attractive even for foreign investors at some point.

> Our focus is on management quality, earnings, balance sheet, pricing power and valuations
>
> **Rajeev Thakkar**
> Chief investment officer, PPFAS Mutual Fund

AI stocks are rising globally, but Indian IT stocks have fallen sharply. How are you expecting them to perform?

AI can potentially improve productivity significantly for developers and others who build custom software. Does it mean that a middle manager or someone who is a non-technical person just goes on to Claude, puts in a prompt and magically the entire company gets computerized? The answer is no. That's taking things to an extreme. Given the improved productivity, Indian companies will add significant value. In fact, you could see an expansion in demand, people could find more use cases, given that they can stretch their IT budgets further with the improved productivity. Even to implement some of these newer AI capabilities, you will require people, and our companies will be able to provide that. Of course, there are some trends one has to be aware of—this trend of global captives coming here, to that extent, the amount of work that gets outsourced reduces because they have their own centres in India. But I think the pessimism is overdone in terms of the sell-off we have seen.

After the war-led correction, what is your view on valuations of different segments of the market?

The sell-off was broad-based. Individual segments that were more sensitive to oil sold off faster and recovered faster after the announcement of a ceasefire. Otherwise, the sell-off was more or less across the board. Our approach is on individual-stock basis, but overall, one has seen a somewhat steeper price correction especially in the small- and mid-cap space. That was also a space which was more overheated about two years ago. So, things are coming back to normal levels gradually. Currently, the bulk of the investments would be in large caps, which is also the nature of the market or the nature of the profit pool—the top 100 companies typically account for 65-75% of the overall profit pool in the country.

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OUR VIEW

ISTOCKPHOTO

What courts could teach us about AI governance

Indian high courts have issued clear instructions barring the use of artificial intelligence in judicial processes. We have much to learn from the judiciary's approach to this technology

Earlier this month, when the Gujarat high court and Punjab and Haryana high court barred judicial officers from using artificial intelligence (AI) for drafting judgements or doing legal research, they set out a clear framework for governing AI in high-stake settings. Judges and court staff are prohibited not only from using AI to decide cases, but also from drafting orders, evaluating evidence or assisting them in judicial reasoning. The Kerala high court took a similar stance in 2025. India's Supreme Court has also kept AI away from the sphere of legal logic. These restrictions follow years of digitization under the e-Courts programme. E-filing, video hearings and real-time case access are routine now, with AI layered in for support. AI is used for transcription, translation and flagging defects in filings, but with human oversight. Tools like Suvas, LegRaa and

moving from a 'techno-legal' stance to enforceable mandates, including labelling requirements. The intent is understandable, but its application raises practical challenges. Who bears responsibility for labelling—the creator, platform or distributor? How is compliance enforced at scale, especially when content is modified or stripped of identifiers? Courts sidestep these ambiguities by regulating points of decision, not flows of content. Accountability lies with the judge who is responsible for the outcome. By excluding AI from influencing that, courts preserve due process and institutional legitimacy. This caution is grounded in the limitations of current AI tools. AI can generate fluent and persuasive outputs but might also fabricate facts. A 'hallucinated' addition to case law—created by court precedent rather than legislation—could imperil justice.

This is not to suggest that the government

THEIR VIEW

Is the US-Israel-Iran ceasefire a pause or tactical turning point?

This conflict's trajectory will depend on whether the adversaries can resolve its structural drivers

HARSH V. PANT
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The US-Iran ceasefire, framed as a two-week conditional truce, offers relief but is less of a resolution than a pause in a fast-escalating crisis. It follows nearly 40 days of sustained US-Israeli military pressure on Iran, itself an extension of the unresolved tensions that persisted after the 2025 Iran-Israel confrontation. In that sense, this ceasefire is simply a momentary recalibration in a longer strategic contest.

At its core, the arrangement reflects a transactional bargain. Washington and Tel Aviv have halted direct strikes on Iran, while Tehran has agreed to ease its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz. The fact that a large fraction of the world's oil trade was at stake underscores how quickly a regional conflict can assume global economic proportions.

Iran's peace proposal, which anchors the upcoming negotiations, is unsurprising. It seeks comprehensive sanctions relief, recognition of its nuclear programme, a rollback of US military presence in the region and formalized non-aggression guarantees under a UN framework. Equally notable is Tehran's attempt to institutionalize its leverage over Hormuz through controlled passage and toll mechanisms, effectively converting a military pressure point into a long-term economic instrument.

For the US, the pause allows the projection of strategic success without further entanglement in an unpopular conflict. For Iran, survival under pressure and the retention of key bargaining chips feeds a narrative of resilience. Israel's acceptance of the truce, while continuing operations in Lebanon, highlights the selective nature of its commitments and ensures that one front of the conflict remains active.

The fragility of this arrangement is already evident. Israeli strikes in Lebanon, continued restrictions in Hormuz and reports of residual military activity across the Gulf point to a ceasefire that is being tested almost as soon as it has been announced. This is characteristic of crisis management in the region: agreements are often operationally ambiguous, allowing actors to interpret compliance in ways that preserve their strategic autonomy.

In the immediate term, there has been a short-lived sense of relief. Oil prices dropped before rebounding amid doubts about the durability of the truce. Financial markets mirrored this volatility. Militarily, the pause in direct US-Iran hostilities is significant, but it coexists with unresolved proxy tensions and an active Israeli campaign in Lebanon.

The next 2-12 weeks will be critical. The Islamabad talks represent a narrow diplomatic window, but the gaps—on enrichment, sanctions and regional posture—remain substantial. The risk is that this ceasefire will become merely a tactical interlude, after which hostilities resume with greater intensity. At the same time, even partial progress could stabilize global energy markets and reduce immediate economic pressures.

Over the long term, the ceasefire's trajectory will hinge on whether it can be transformed into a durable political framework. That, in turn, depends on the willingness of adversaries to move beyond maximalist positions toward a calibrated accommodation of each other's core concerns. If the current moment is leveraged effectively, it could reopen space for a limited revival of nuclear diplomacy, perhaps through incremental understandings on enrichment caps, monitoring mechanisms and phased sanctions relief. This approach would privilege stability over resolution.

Equally significant would be the implications for America's regional posture. Sustained de-escalation could enable it to recalibrate its military footprint in West Asia, shifting from direct engagement to a more distant balancing role. This would align with a broader strategic inclination to reduce exposure in protracted regional conflicts while retaining the capacity to intervene when necessary.

Failure remains the more plausible outcome. The gaps are not merely technical, but deeply political, rooted in incompatible threat perceptions and entrenched mistrust. A breakdown of talks would likely trigger a resumption of hostilities, pushing up prices and amplifying global inflationary pressures. Critically, the risk of horizontal escalation across Lebanon and beyond would grow, drawing in proxies and raising the probability of miscalculation.

What emerges, then, is a familiar regional pattern: a ceasefire that provides temporary respite while leaving underlying conflicts intact. In this sense, it is a test of whether incremental diplomacy can arrest a cycle of escalation that has proven remarkably resilient thus far.

QUICK READ

The two-week truce in the Gulf war provides some respite by easing immediate economic pressures across the world but a return to escalation could follow a breakdown in peace talks.

Enduring peace requires the principal actors to seize this opportunity and resolve the conflict's underlying motivations through incremental diplomacy that's carefully calibrated.

Supace assist research and access, but do not influence judicial outcomes. Hence, the recent curbs are best understood as a careful line being drawn around AI. They don't reject but confine this technology. AI is being embraced as a tool for efficiency, but kept out of decision-making to preserve human agency in matters of justice. After all, this is a domain where errors—especially AI 'hallucinations'—can be disastrous.

The Gujarat high court's policy is illustrative for its clarity of demarcation. The evaluation of evidence, writing of rulings and the rationale behind them are treated as non-negotiable human domains. However, administrative tasks such as transcription and case management remain open to tech assistance. This approach stands in contrast with the government's tightening grip on the internet. Faced with deepfakes and synthetic media, policymakers are should replicate the judicial model. Courts have a narrower mandate and operate within a controlled setting, while governments must balance innovation, economic growth, public safety and fundamental rights. While courts can keep AI out of decision-making, businesses and other operations may find its use worthwhile at various levels. Even so, the judiciary's approach offers a useful template. It has identified where the risks are most acute and least reversible and sought to curb exactly those. Yet, rather than stifle AI adoption, it allows the controlled use of this technology in lower-risk areas. Crucially, it anchors all AI use in a clear bedrock of human accountability. The country's broad policy challenge is to define where human judgement is an absolute must, and then enforce restraints effectively, rather than rely on rules that may come to exist only on paper.

10 YEARS AGO

JUST A THOUGHT

> The essence of justice often involves ethical considerations, empathy, and contextual understanding- elements that remain beyond the reach of algorithms

BHUSHAN RAMKRISHNA GAVAI

THEIR VIEW

Are our diplomatic and economic strategies working?

ARUN MAIRA

is a former member of the erstwhile Planning Commission.

An image on the 3 April cover of *The Economist* shows an angry US President Donald Trump shouting on one side, with China's President Xi Jinping calmly smiling on the other. "Never interrupt your enemy when he is making a mistake," says the headline.

A revealing picture in the White House's archives shows US National Security Advisor Henry Kissinger and Chinese Premier Zhou Enlai shaking hands in Beijing on 9 July 1971, when Kissinger made his secret dash for a *détente* with China. The press was told that Kissinger was unwell and resting in Pakistan. President Yahya Khan of Pakistan had arranged the meeting, which was followed by another between Richard Nixon and Mao Zedong on 21 February 1972 to formalize the *détente* that Trump has ended.

The Zhou-Kissinger picture captures the two countries' approaches to diplomacy: an eager Kissinger reaching out for Zhou's hand and a gracious Zhou reciprocating. Kissinger contrasted the two approaches. The Chinese approach, he said, was historically grounded, philosophically oriented and based on thinking in terms of a process over decades. He contrasted that with US diplomacy, which tends to seek quick agreements and focus on immediate outcomes (Trump's 'art of the deal'). Since then, the difference has become a template: for Americans, urgency and immediacy matter; and for the Chinese, patience and civilizational time. As Kissinger said: "The Americans have a list of things... the Chinese have an objective."

This is a historic example of 'triple-loop thinking' in diplomacy: not just what each side wants, but how each side understands time itself. From this springs 'triple-loop learning,' which refers to how individuals or organizations learn at progressively deeper levels. It extends ideas from organizational learning developed by thinkers such as Chris Argyris and Donald Schön. Think of the three 'loops' as layers of reflection.

Single-loop learning asks, 'Are we doing things right?' This is the most basic level. You notice a problem and correct it without questioning the underlying assumptions. It is about improving efficiency within existing rules. Example: If a project is delayed, you work faster or adjust the schedule.

Double-loop learning asks, 'Are we doing the right things?' Here, you step back and question the assumptions, policies, or goals behind your actions. You may need to change strategy, not just the execution. Example: Instead of speeding up the project, you ask whether its design, goals, or timelines are flawed.

Triple-loop learning asks 'How do we decide what is right?' This is the deepest level. You reflect on the frameworks, values and ways of thinking that shape decisions. You ask how you define success, learn and interpret reality. Example: You examine how your organization defines 'success, how decisions are made, whose voices count and whether your approach to planning needs to change.

Former prime minister Manmohan Singh invited me to join India's Planning Commission in 2009 with a special charge: to reform the way plans were being made and implemented. China had gone far ahead of India in terms of all three objectives of India's five-year plans: faster, more inclusive and more sustainable growth. Both were equally poor until the 1980s. Then their trajectories diverged. China's GDP is about five times ours, its manufacturing sector eight times larger and its high-tech sector 50 times.

Development involves learning to do what a country could not and acquiring new capabilities. China's policymakers have proven to be faster learners than India's. China also made five-year plans. The difference lay in how their plans were made and their content. Above all, China's leaders stayed on their socialist course, insisting that the purpose of the state is to promote the welfare of people, not serve private interests, while India's leaders jumped ship too soon; persuaded by the Washington Consensus, India joined the neo-liberal voyage of market orientation in 1991.

Triple-loop learning turns leadership from problem-solving into meaning-making. It is difficult because leaders must question their own mental models. It is a discipline of reflection: identifying your assumptions, examining how they were formed and rethinking them if need be. Our leaders must rethink three assumptions.

First, in the strategic sphere, the assumption that getting closer to the US will secure India better against Pakistan and China, with which we have unsettled border disputes. Another assumption is that Israel, a colonial Jewish state amid Muslim-majority Asian countries, one that's dependent on the US for its survival, can be a viable strategic partner.

Second, in the economic sphere, India should give up the thinking that has guided its policies since 1991—that expansion of international trade should come before building stronger domestic industries. A country with the largest population in the world must build more industries for its own needs. We need not just more pathways for sustainable employment, but also strategic independence from foreign technologies.

Third, the hallucinatory assumption that India can be a country good for only its Hindu majority. For India to become strong, secure and a democratic beacon for the world, all our citizens—whatever their religion, ethnicity or caste, rich or poor—must be treated as equals. And they must feel equal too.

QUICK READ

Leaders must adopt triple-loop learning. Don't just ask if we're doing things right or even if we're doing the right things but also how we determine what are the right things to do.

It is a discipline of reflection that demands an examination of core assumptions. India would be well advised to rethink some of these in the strategic, economic and social spheres.

MY VIEW | STAT-CRAFT

From access to agency: Reset the goal for women's empowerment

Increased participation in the Indian economy isn't sufficient. Women should be empowered to shape our economic outcomes

RAJESH SHUKLA
is managing director and chief executive officer of People Research on India's Consumer Economy.

ISTOCKPHOTO

India's development narrative increasingly places women at the centre of an economic transformation. As Parliament prepares to operationalize the Women's Reservation Act ahead of the 2029 elections, the focus on women's participation in public life is intensifying. Over the past decade, policy efforts have expanded women's access to bank accounts, jobs and entrepreneurship. On paper, the gains are significant. But a closer look reveals a more complicated story, one where inclusion has expanded but empowerment remains uneven. If India is serious about becoming a developed economy by 2047, it must move beyond counting how many

MINT CURATOR

Can this ceasefire relieve retail investors of gloom? Maybe not

They may become disillusioned if Indian equity returns stay weak

ANDY MUKHERJEE
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering industrial companies and financial services in Asia.

Indians have been shifting their money from banks to mutual funds. ISTOCKPHOTO

Throughout this decade, India's household savings have steadily left the safety of bank deposits to chase returns in equities. This was supposed to provide a stable pool of risk capital to entrepreneurs and act as a shock absorber against fickle hot-money inflows from overseas. The Iran war punched holes in this cheery thesis that a ceasefire may not mend.

For the first time since the pandemic, individual investors were net sellers in the secondary market in the first 11 months of 2025-26. That sign of pessimism, which pre-dates the war, could become more pronounced because of the conflict. Much of the 19% annualized three-year return on the Nifty Smallcap 100 Index came from a bumper performance in 2023 and early 2024. That will soon vanish. If the bench- capital-gains and securities transaction taxes—a buzzkill for global fund managers.

Besides, valuations may still need to become a lot more reasonable. On a price-earnings basis, the MSCI India Index is 70% more expensive than the MSCI Emerging Markets Index. While this premium is lower than at its 2024 peak, global investors clearly expect India Inc to cost even less.

That's because of the elephant in the room: the rupee. Foreign investors usually factor in 5% annual depreciation to evaluate dollar-denominated returns. Over the past

women are included and start asking whether they actually have control over opportunities.

Consider financial inclusion. According to the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), nearly 79% of women in India now have a bank account that they themselves use, up from 53% a few years earlier. Government data also show that women hold over 55% of Jan Dhan accounts, with a large share concentrated in rural areas. These are remarkable achievements. Yet, access does not automatically translate into autonomy. Only about 54% of women report owning and using a mobile phone, and an even smaller proportion regularly access the internet via mobile devices. In practice, many women remain dependent on others to use financial services. A bank account without control is inclusion without empowerment.

A similar pattern is visible in the labour market. Female labour force participation has risen sharply in recent years. According to the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), it increased from around 23% in 2017-18 to over 41% in 2023-24. This reversal of a long-term decline is significant. But the story does not end there. Much of this increase is concentrated in rural areas and informal work, including agriculture and self-employment. These jobs often lack stability, social protection and opportunities for growth. Women are working more, but not necessarily in ways that enhance their economic security or independence. Notably, a significant share of women workers remain classified as self-employed or unpaid family workers, highlighting persistent informality.

The deeper issue lies in the distinction between access and agency. Development is not only about providing resources, but about expanding people's ability to use them meaningfully. In the same way, empowerment requires the capacity to make choices and act on them, rather than merely having access to opportunities.

One of the biggest barriers to this agency is unpaid care work. Data from India's latest Time Use Survey show that women spend over 300 minutes a day on unpaid domestic work, while men spend far less time. Around 41% of women are engaged in caregiving activities, nearly double the proportion of men. Even among those employed, time spent on unpaid work remains disproportionately high.

This has profound economic consequences. Women's entry into the workforce is layered on top of their existing responsibilities at home; this creates a 'double burden.' It limits the kind of jobs they can take, the hours they can work and their ability to pursue skills or scale businesses.

Yet, policy discussions rarely treat care as an economic issue. It is still seen as a private matter. This is a mistake. Investment in child- and elder-care is not welfare; it is a form of soft infrastructure that enables economic participation.

Another emerging constraint is the digital divide. While India has rapidly expanded digital infrastructure, women remain less connected. Estimates suggest that only about 37% of women use mobile internet services, compared to much higher rates among men. This gap is wider in rural areas, where affordability and connectivity constraints persist.

Entrepreneurship tells a similar story. Government data shows that over 30 million women-led enterprises are registered in India. This is often cited as evidence of growing empowerment. But most of these businesses are micro-enterprises, operating with limited capital and market access. Their contribution to employment and value addition remains constrained.

If women entrepreneurs are to thrive, they need more than entry points. They need access to credit, digital tools, supply chains and markets. In short, they need a supportive ecosystem.

So, what should change?

First, policy must shift from access to capability. Financial inclusion needs to be complemented with financial literacy and digital skills. Without these, inclusion will remain superficial.

Second, the care economy must be brought to the centre of policy design. Public investment in childcare, flexible work arrangements and support systems can significantly expand women's participation.

Third, improving the quality of employment must become a priority. This means creating jobs that are not only accessible to women, but also secure, well-paying and growth-oriented.

Fourth, digital inclusion must be treated as a gender issue. Ensuring that women have access to devices, connectivity and digital skills is essential for their participation in a modern economy.

Finally, policy must engage with social norms. Economic opportunities alone cannot overcome deeply embedded cultural constraints. Change requires sustained effort across education, media and communities.

We have made undeniable progress in expanding opportunities for women. But the next stage of development will depend on whether these translate into real empowerment.

The difference between access and agency is the difference between participation and power. If India wants to fully realize its economic potential, it must ensure that women are not just included in the economy, but are able to shape it.

QUICK READ

We must make a distinction between access and agency. Access to public provisions is not enough. Women must have the power to make their own choices and act on them.

This is of utmost importance. For India to fully realize its economic potential, it must ensure that women are not just included in the economy, but are actively able to shape it.

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mark stalls at current levels, the new three-year return in March 2027 will be just 1.3%.

Unless valuations reset at more attractive levels, the psychological shock of low realized gains could pour cold water over expectations of future outperformance. At risk are systematic investment plans, through which the middle class has poured nearly ₹6 trillion into mutual funds since early 2024. These plans are the "big bang" phenomenon for the Indian capital market, Bernstein noted. "We remain watchful of how retail investors behave if markets remain sideways for the next 12 months," its analysts said.

Should people stop wiring small sums of money every month to mutual funds, the intermediaries that depend on them could be in big trouble. Before Wednesday's ceasefire-inspired stock-market surge, HDFC Asset Management's shares had fallen about 15% over six months. Brokerage Motilal Oswal had tumbled 25%.

Investment bankers are also on edge. From Mukesh Ambani's digital empire to the National Stock Exchange, large initial public offerings are in the works. Beyond those marquee names, however, there may not be much investor appetite. PhonePe has delayed its IPO. Expect others to follow suit.

Ambani's Jio Platforms listing is likely to consist entirely of an offer for sale by existing investors such as Meta and Alphabet. The company won't receive fresh funding. This reflects a trend. Last year, more than 60% of the IPO fundraising in India ended up giving exits to firms' original sponsors. The money didn't create fresh assets. In fact, a lot of it may have left the country.

Overall, overseas investors have sold $22 billion of Indian equities over the past year. What will it take to bring them back? For one thing, New Delhi should rethink its

year, the rupee has weakened 8%. That's a dampener, and not just for overseas investors. Affluent Indian households—the bulwark of India's market—also have substantial foreign-currency liabilities. Effectively, their lifestyle is dollarized.

A lot is riding on the two-week ceasefire in the Gulf conflict. If the Strait of Hormuz reopens quickly and fully, India's fiscal and current-account deficits may be elevated, but manageable. However, prolonged energy shortages could upend those calculations and the Reserve Bank of India, which left interest rates unchanged on Wednesday, may have to raise them to prevent an unruly collapse of the currency.

For a bank-led economy, large-scale migration of household savings into capital markets was always a risky strategy. The number of participants in the National Stock Exchange's secondary market quintupled in five years through February 2025. From fund managers and distributors to exchanges and brokers, an entire industry benefited. For a time, this 'financialization' of deposits sustained optimism by producing a wealth effect. Banks enabled their own hollowing out by lending ever-larger sums for share purchases. However, a lot of that money fed a speculative frenzy in low-quality, small-cap stocks.

Costs are mounting. Indian lenders are strapped for liquidity, which means borrowers aren't getting the full benefit of RBI's cumulative 125 basis points of rate cuts since early last year. Meanwhile, savers can no longer find attractive yields in equities. The rank of new retail entrants thinned by 24.5% in February.

Throw in the shock of seeing three-year returns dwindle to nothing, and both investors and intermediaries may have a tough slog ahead.

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MY VIEW | PEN DRIVE

A ceasefire on making predictions would serve us well

RAHUL JACOB

is a former Financial Times foreign correspondent.

Has economic forecasting ever seemed so fraught with risk? A mix of almost imponderable new possibilities made possible by AI and the unpredictable state of the world makes people who trade contracts on so-called prediction markets seem foolhardy. Still, spare a kind thought for those of us in the commentariat who must hedge our prophesying.

Put aside for a moment how long the truce between the US, Israel and Iran will last. And, if it does, how to estimate the huge backlog of ships and tankers waiting to transit through the Strait of Hormuz and how long this will take to clear. There is plenty else where outcomes seem more binary than ever. Take the concerns about private credit markets and bets made by private equity giants. Is it containable, given the limits on redemption and withdrawals that would prevent a Silicon Valley Bank-style bank-run crisis? Or are second-order effects likely?

Last week, Blue Owl Capital, a large New York-based private credit and investment firm, reported that investors had sought to withdraw $5.4 billion from two of its premier funds in the first quarter. On Monday, JPMorgan Chase's Jamie Dimon warned that "losses on all leveraged lending will be higher than expected," yet another broadside directed at private credit firms.

Then there is the dollar, a now perennial puzzle. Amid alarm at how long the Third Gulf War looks set to handicap the global economy, the dollar has—surprise—risen. This is despite non-US central banks having sold $82 billion worth of US Treasuries, as the *Financial Times* reported, after the war of choice started. That sell-off, it turns out, was offset not just by rising dollar demand as oil prices rose, but also by long Treasury positions held by hedge funds. As large as the hedge fund industry is, the dollar's strength in March was mystifying. This week, a former Pentagon budget expert at the American Enterprise Institute estimated that five weeks of war against Iran has cost the US government $22-31 billion. In addition, something in the order of $10 trillion in Treasuries needs to be rolled over in 2026. Confidence in the US and its erratic administration will be tested.

Meanwhile, another surprise: gold prices have mostly fallen in the wake of the war. This last nugget cheered me considerably. Even a fraction of money tied up in gold would grease the wheels of the economy if it were freed up. But part of the reason for my delight in gold's seemingly inexorable rise coming to a halt is that I opted not to buy gold ETFs more than a year ago. I thought it was medieval. Now, I feel just a little less foolish. Chastened, I am looking to take a punt on precious metals by buying a large silver teapot. My rationale is that it will at least be a calming device to counter the roller-coaster volatility in equity shares I expect in the year or two ahead. Besides, the Art Deco teapot I inherited is hard to get tea leaves out of, a case of stylish form winning over substance.

All this strikes me as a shamefully Marie Antoinettesque approach to a world in turmoil. Just weeks ago, for instance, many predicted fertilizer shortages and worried where food prices were headed. Yet, recent reports from agricultural *mandis* show that vegetable demand has dropped and prices are crashing.

It has been a little over a year since the Trump administration's arbitrary tariffs were announced, prompting many economists to predict that prices in the US would rise sharply and its economy would be hard hit. Instead, its GDP growth chugged along at around 2.1% in 2025, with investment in data centres and AI being credited for it.

Many predicted that US retailers would significantly raise prices after those tariffs were imposed. I was in two minds because from 2010 to 2013, I had been in and out of factories in the southern Chinese province of Guangdong, the world's most dynamic factory floor. Part of my reporting took me to the Guangzhou Trade Fair. Eavesdropping on conversations between buyers and suppliers there made me gasp at how fat most retail margins were, notably in the US. So, it was not entirely a surprise that retailers reduced their plump margins and price rises in the US were consequently more muted than expected.

Having watched how our South Asian neighbours have benefitted from a glut in Chinese solar panels, I decided I would use the fog of war to prod my resident welfare association into installing some. I argued that solar energy would mean the housing complex could use a clean source instead of diesel when generators were needed. As so often happens with efforts on pollution, this email was met with... silence.

I worry about supply chain disruptions. The Gulf War has lasted far longer than leaders of Israel and the US had bargained for and the current break in hostilities seems somewhat tenuous. On the home front, I am, belatedly and unoriginally, trying to get on a waiting list for an induction stove. At work, I am proposing a unilateral, one-man ceasefire on making predictions as a columnist. I will adopt the late Chinese premier Zhou Enlai's long-view approach. Asked about the impact of the French Revolution in 1789, he famously replied that it was too early to say.

QUICK READ

Amid wars of choice, sudden ceasefires, currency swings and potential crises such as the one private credit looks headed for, it has become almost foolhardy to make economic forecasts.

Those who comment on world events may find it worthwhile to adopt a long-view approach. We could take a cue from what Zhou Enlai said about the impact of the 1789 French Revolution.

A culinary cruise through Rajasthan

Poila Boishakh food festival at Bengaluru's Radisson Blu.

For the weekend

Of food, art and a drag show

A *Mint* guide to what's happening in

A motorcycle ride through the desert is a great way to taste the regional variations of the state's fiery mutton curries

Rishad Saam Mehta

The 1,600km loop across the state covered desert highways, old caravan towns and fortress cities, and included a variety of meat dishes and milk-based drinks.

Rajasthan does not pamper the traveller. It roasts you in the afternoon sun, powders your jacket and motorcycle with dust and stretches the horizon until the road feels endless. But it rewards endurance in its own way. Somewhere beyond the next fort wall or desert dune there is always a kitchen waiting, a fire burning low, and a cook who understands hunger better than any nutritionist ever could. Beyond the courtyards and frescoed havelis lies a land that takes its food seriously.

Royal Enfield's Culinary Cruise was a week-long 1,600km loop across Rajasthan on a Super Meteor 650, where the riding was serious and the eating even more so. The route covered desert highways, old caravan towns and fortress cities, but the real milestones were the kitchens.

From manicured Jaipur, the transition to the little lanes of Mandawa was an easy 190km warm-up, a chance to let the 648cc motorcycle find its rhythm. The Shekhawati region is famously the "open-air art gallery" of Rajasthan, but to walk through it is to see heritage collide with monstrous neglect. While beautiful frescos on the havelis offer a glimpse of Marwari riches, the experience is marred by the pervasive stink of open sewers.

SPICE, SUGAR AND STONE

However, the desert offers prizes to those who endure its harsher side. At our hotel, the Desert Resort, the chef provided an antidote in the form of *rajwadi maas*, a traditional mutton dish cooked for four hours over a wood stove. The air was filled with the toasted scent of *bajra* rotis, leavened by hand and roasted on a flat cast-iron pan. When the meal arrived, it was a delight: a thick, fire-roasted roti lacquered in ghee with the *rajwadi maas* ladled directly over it, served with a shard of jaggery and a hit of garlic chutney. Digging into that slow-cooked masterpiece made the ride to Shekhawati worth it.

We were on the road to Bikaner next, a chaotic city with smells of frying gram flour and ancient stone in the air. To arrive here on the Super Meteor 650 is to participate in a high-stakes mechanical ballet. At the Kote Gate, the wide tarmac suddenly constricts into a labyrinth of rickshaws, cows and disorderly, noisy traffic. Parking the motorcycle felt like docking a heavy ship in a crowded harbour.

The Bikaner food walk is a test of fortitude. Coming from Mumbai, where even the humblest street vendor makes a cursory nod to hygiene with a pair of gloves, the old city of Bikaner is a culture shock. At Kote Gate, we ate *papdi* chaat, everything crushed, handled and mixed with bare fingers. It was undeniably tasty yet I couldn't help but wonder if my stomach possessed the structural integrity to handle the microbiological gauntlet being thrown down.

From there, we headed to Chunnilal Sharbat Wala, where rows of bottles glistened like paint samples in a hardware store. They were delicious certainly, but essentially synthetic cocktails of colour and artificial flavour held together by viscous sugar syrup.

Redemption was the Kadhai Doodh, milk constantly agitated in a massive iron *kadai* heated by a slow flame and embellished with dry fruits, cardamom and saffron. It's ladled into an earthen *kullad* with *malai* skimmed from the top. The concoction was fabulous.

When I thumbed the starter of the motorcycle the next morning it was with a mix of relief and pride. Despite the *papri*, sherbets and *doodh* thumb-stirred with *malai*, my stomach had held out like Rajputs against a Mughal siege.

In Jodhpur, the theatre began at Ghanta Garh, the iconic Clock Tower, where the air is filled with the cacophony of horns and hawkers. At Shahi Samosa and Arora Namkeen, two savoury snack stalwarts situated side by side, the *mirchi vadas* were golden fried, gram-paste coated behemoths. The samosas were literal calorie bombs. I had to choose—maintain the discipline of my low-fat, high-protein diet or surrender to the call of the carbs. The calorie bombs won. Some snacks are simply too delicious for a diet to survive, especially if they are arguably the best samosas in Rajasthan.

I headed to the legendary Shri Mishrilal Hotel for their Makhaniya Lassi. This is less of a drink and more of an Indian custard—a saffron-heavy, cardamom-infused yogurt so thick it requires a spoon and a moment of quiet contemplation. It was the ultimate cooling agent after the hard ride in the heat from Jaisalmer to Jodhpur.

A FLAVOUR MAP

As the sun dipped, we traded the dusty chaos of the bazaar for the rooftop of Hotel Pal, where we were at eye-level with the illuminated ramparts of Mehrangarh Fort, which glowed like a golden crown against the sky. Dinner here was about the white elegance of *safed maas*. Unlike its fiery cousins, this mutton curry is bathed in a velvety sauce of yogurt, cream, cashews and almonds. It's flavoured with "cool" spices—cardamom and mace—and finished with a hint of rose water. It was mellow and rich.

Reaching Jaisalmer, we checked into Karwaan, where the transition from the bike's saddle to the comforts of the camp was almost jarring. We found ourselves reclining against heavy bolsters like Marwari emissaries and watching local folk performances.

Chef Sachin Singh crafted a smashingly good *laal maas*. The mise en place looked like a small military operation: 4kg of goat meat, 2kg of ghee, mountains of onions, bowls of curd and spices, and enough Mathania chilli to start a diplomatic dispute. As the fire settled into a steady glow, the pot went on and the transformation began. Ghee hissed, onions softened, spices bloomed and the meat slowly surrendered to the heat. *Laal maas* is not a dish that rushes. It simmers with patience, gathering depth and fire in equal measure, until the sauce thickens into something unapologetically Rajasthani.

From the golden sands, the road twisted towards the rugged granite spine of the Aravallis to Ghanerao. This region has long had strategic importance, guarding the ancient passes between the kingdoms of Marwar and Mewar. Tucked away in this gateway is Aloof Jungle Lodge, where we had a lunch of *dal baati churma*, a "tick-the-box" culinary ritual for any Rajasthan journey.

It was at Aloof that we encountered *godwari maas*, the smokier, more primitive cousin to the city's refined curries. While the iconic *laal maas* relies on the sharp, clean heat of the *Mathania chili*, this dish is a more atmospheric affair that draws its character from the landscape. The meat is slow braised for hours over an open fire fuelled by local acacia wood, which imparts a distinct, resinous char to the gravy. The result is a flavour map of the land—earthy, intensely smoky, and far more complex than any standard meat preparation.

When I finally rolled back into Jaipur, the odometer read 1,600km but my stomach felt like it had travelled twice that distance. Rajasthan is not a place you merely ride through. It is a place that feeds you, tests you, occasionally terrifies your digestive system, and then sends you back on to the highway slightly heavier and much happier.

Rishad Saam Mehta is a Mumbai-based independent travel and automotive writer.

Write to us at feedback@livemint.com

and around your city

BENGALURU

POILA BOISHAKH

14-19 April

Celebrate Nobo Borsho or Poila Boishakh with a Bengali food festival, curated by executive sous chef Nirupam Guha. On offer will be *kosha mangsho, bhapa maach, shorshe maach, luchi, mishti doi*, among others.

12.30-3.30pm/6.30-11pm. Mélange, Radisson Blu Bengaluru, Marathahalli.

MUMBAI

BATTLE ROYALE

11 April

Enjoy drag performances by artists like Seventeen Sins, Mysterious Munda, Zeesh, Betta Naan Stop and Emperor Naaz at this event that aims to celebrate queer artistry and inclusivity. The evening will also feature a live set by DJ Atharva.

8pm. House of Commons, Kitty Su, The Lalit, Andheri East. For details, call 8104769797 or visit in.bookmyshow.com

AAMNE SAAMNE

13 April

Directed and written by Niraj Shirvaikar, this 150-minute Marathi comedy follows two couples—one married for over three decades, and the other in a live-in relationship. The play examines the evolving nature of marriage and how relationships transform over time.

8.30pm. Vishnudas Bhave Natyagruha, Vashi, Navi Mumbai. For details, visit in.bookmyshow.com

By Thomas Henriot.

DELHI

THE WEIGHT OF LIGHT

12 April-12 May

This is a solo exhibition of works by French contemporary artist Thomas Henriot. It brings together large-scale ink drawings created in India and later transformed in France into monumental tapestries using an advanced jacquard weaving technique developed by Lyon-based textile house Brochier Soieries.

11am-6pm (Sundays closed). Art Centrix Space, Jain Farm, Vasant Kunj. For details, visit www.artcentrix.com

'Tourism pollution' spoils the mood in Japan

While officials push for tourism-led growth, residents across the country remain divided over the surge in tourists

AP

The trouble started with a beautiful photo.

Social media was soon awash with the lovely view of Japan's snow-capped Mount Fuji looming over a red pagoda and the short-lived cherry blossoms that herald the approach of spring.

Tourists wanting a similar shot soon packed this peaceful town at the foot of the mountain. The complaints were not far behind: chronic traffic jams; piles of litter; ill-mannered foreigners knocking on doors of private homes to borrow toilets; tourists relieving themselves in front yards. It got so bad officials in Fujiyoshida announced in February that they were cancelling this year's annual cherry blossom festival, which started as a way to promote tourism a decade ago.

What locals are calling "tourism pollution" has illuminated a broader problem for Japan: As the country's economic malaise deepens, officials are eager for the economic boost of increased tourism, even as local communities find themselves entirely unprepared for what a small army of foreign visitors means for their communities.

"This area is primarily an ordinary residential neighborhood, where balancing (tourism) with the safety of people's living environment has become difficult," Masatoshi Hada, manager of the Fujiyoshida Economics and Environment Department, told The Associated Press. "We decided not to promote a festival that would invite more visitors."

Even without the festival, foreign tourists packed the area on a sunny day in early April when cherry blossoms reached their prime. The narrow streets up to the popular Arakurayama Sengen Park were filled as the visitors lined up for a chance film the world-famous panoramic views.

In recent years, foreign tourists have exceeded 10,000 per day in the area, something that has "threatened residents' daily lives," the city said in a statement in February.

Overtourism has also been seen in other popular destinations in Japan, like Kyoto and Kamakura. In Kyoto, locals complain of tourists with large suitcases clogging city buses. "Tourism pollution" comes as Japan confronts a rapidly growing population of foreign workers brought in as the country's population dwindles and ages.

Tourists capture views of the snow-capped Mount Fuji. ISTOCKPHOTO

The combination has led to xenophobia, and Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi 's nationalistic government has proposed tougher rules on foreigners. Even as it promises to address overtourism concerns, the government wants to boost the current level of 40 million inbound tourists to 60 million visitors by 2030.

Beginning April 1, at the start of the region's cherry blossom season, Fujiyoshida increased its security guards and restricted entry of tour buses and vehicles into the scenic neighbourhood, requiring visitors to reach the park on foot.

On a recent day, security guard Hiroaki Nagayama gestured to passersby so they would stay out of busy areas. He asked tourists to throw cigarette butts in designated places and tried to help the lost.

"I'm struggling. I cannot communicate with them in Japanese. Some people buy food at stalls and leave litter behind," Nagayama says. "I think what's happening here is a typical example of overtourism."

Sitting on a bench outside his house just a couple of blocks away, Hitoshi Mori, 93, says having many visitors is "good but annoying."

"It's too crowded outside so I can only get groceries once a week and stock up on food," he says.

Tourists, meanwhile, seem delighted by the spectacular view, despite many signs popping up that order them to behave better. There are also hours-long lines to get to cherished scenic spots.

"It's pretty (well) organized. When they let you come in, you have like five minutes to take as many pictures as you can, and it was amazing," said Lisa Goerdert from Paris.

Vicky Tran, who came from Melbourne, Australia, with her family and friends, said they could not go all the way up to see the pagoda with Mount Fuji and the cherry blossoms, because it was too crowded. Still, she said she enjoyed the view and the neighbourhood.

The overtourism has opened divisions between residents who want quiet and those who have started businesses using their yards to operate toll parking or setting up new shops or food stalls.

In a nearby shopping arcade that once had many closed mom-and-pop shops, business has picked up after another viral social media shot showed Mount Fuji looming over the street.

Throngs of tourists stand in the street to take photos of Mount Fuji, often blocking traffic, with frustrated vehicles honking.

The sudden flood of visitors is a huge change "for people like us who are used to a quiet suburban lifestyle," says Masami Nakamura, who runs a decades-old school uniform shop with her husband. "I only hope the tourists respect our rules and manners."

The crowds are a big change even for those who are seeing increased business.

"I once almost hit a tourist who jumped into the street without looking," said Kyoko Funakubo, a 60-year-old employee at a local hotel and a part-time vendor selling Fuji-themed souvenirs. "This place used to be almost abandoned, with many shuttered shops. But now, with many stores reopened or new shops that have opened, I feel good seeing this area come alive again."

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